A Drop of Blood

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A Drop of Blood

by Xenakis (IceRosesCrown)

Summary

Castaspella has lived a long life...
A *very* long life...
This is her story...
Which threatens to end soon...
If she doesn't drink, at least, a drop of blood...

Notes

Hello everyone! This is a little halloween special I have decided to start posting... Aka, you can expect next update next year <("^_^)

But heeey! It comes with some art!
And it's at the very least a year old, maybe a bit more, so it's a miracle I'm even posting this at all!









Anyways, I sure hope you enjoy this, and many thanks to Series_Shipper for betareading and supporting me ^_^

Happy Halloween everyone!! <|:D

Chapter 1

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

> —Bea! Beatrix, wake up!— Castaspella pleaded, desperate. —Oh, Stars… I can't have… Could I? Oh, no, no, no!
>
> Unable to hold back anymore, she began crying uncontrollably while holding the unconscious woman against her chest.
>
> Everything afterwards happened too quickly…
>
> Taking her to the hospital, having to lie about what had and hadn't happened, and finally getting the necessary help for her wife…

—Es?

—Ah!

Castaspella woke up, startled upon hearing her name.

—What happened? What were you dreaming about? Was it a nightmare?

—I- No. I'm sorry, Bea…

—Just tell me what happened— she insisted, sitting on the bed, closer to her.

But she didn't want to tell her how, even after five years, she still had the memory of that incident so fresh in her mind.

—Ah… I can't lie to you— she sighed. —I just… recalled that time when… you passed out…

—Es, we have discussed this many times…

—I know. That's why I didn't want to tell you, but I know you'd only worry even more.

—Indeed.

Castaspella sighed once more and leant against her wife, resting on her chest.

—Was I screaming again?

—Just kept shifting a lot…

—Oh…

—You almost got the sheets off the bed.

They both laughed together, enjoying this little moment, before finally getting up to prepare breakfast.

The mansion was empty save for them.

It used to be full of servants before but, five years ago, everything changed.

While they busied themselves in the kitchen, Castaspella's mind returned to the past. And she had quite a long past…

There had been better and worse times; she had had to learn to enjoy the present rather than yearn for the past or regret what can't be changed.

But that's always a challenge for vampires.

Having seen so much, having lived so much… who wouldn't fall back into the loop of regret and yearning?

And, as everything had changed considerably, it was like a constant reminder.

Five years are but a blink for a Castaspella.

—Ah…— she sighed.

—Something wrong?

—No, not at all— she denied. —I'm just tired, as usual.

—You know why that is— her wife reminded her.

—Yes, and I don't care— Castaspella replied, severe.

—You can be so stubborn, my Love— she lamented.

—It's not stubbornness! I made an oath, and I don't plan on breaking it.

—I know.

But Castaspella understood why she was so insistent.

—I promise you, I may look a bit worse than usual, but it's not that bad— she comfortingly said, approaching from behind to hug her. —I made my choice as you made yours. So, we're both in similar conditions now; can't you support me like I've supported you?

—Es, what I did was utterly egocentric; what you are doing, on the other hand, is utterly selfless. A bit *too* selfless, I'd say— her wife complained. —In fact, you shouldn't support me at all…

—Well, I'm not going to approve of what you did, but I will always support you and try to help with the health issues that parasite causes you— Castaspella argued. —Listen to me, Bea: everyone else may now see you differently, but I know you like they don't. They only see "Shadow Weaver", like before they would only see "Light Spinner", but I know that you, Beatrix, are much more than that.

—Now you just sound naïve, Esmeralda. One would think you'd be able to recognize a monster when you see one— Shadow Weaver spat, knowing perfectly well how bad that sounded.

—And now you are just being a *jerk*— Castaspella retorted, letting go of her. —Listen to me: you are *not* a monster! You're quite spiteful, egocentric, reckless, and a plethora of other things, but you're *not* a monster!— she stated, grabbing her wife by the shoulder to make her turn around. —I have, in fact, met plenty of them, including the one that… turned me. So, yes, I *can* recognize a monster when I see one, and you are *not* one of them!

—There are a couple of children who would think differently— she insisted.

—Children are children! Of course they will call you a monster for how you treated them! But that doesn't mean you are one, just that you are a terrible caregiver!

—In this world, it's the same. Harming a kid is unforgivable, and if it weren't for you, I would have never realized what I was actually doing to them!

—But don't you see how you're reacting? If you were a monster, you wouldn't care about the pain and suffering you caused; on the contrary, you would even take pride in it!

—Just…— Shadow Weaver exclaimed, raising her voice a second. She then lowered it to continue —…Understand that I did something unforgivable that took a toll on my health, while you're sacrificing yours, willingly… and for something that wasn't even your fault.

After that, they both remained silent.

They never knew what to say when the discussion reached this point.

—A-alright. I think we should eat before our coffees go cold, yes?— Castaspella eventually let out, smiling gently.

—Yes, yes. We both need it.

After their breakfast, the women each went to do as they pleased, so, while Castaspella sat on the lounge with her knitting, Shadow Weaver went to her underground workshop to mix a couple of potions.

Their typical weekend morning.

Though it didn't *feel* typical at all…

Neither could have imagined what was going through the other's mind. They both took pride in how well they knew their partner, but… Did they really know each other as much as they believed?

While focused on her knitting, Castaspella kept musing about a lot of things. From the memory she dreamt about, to the little discussion with her wife, it sometimes felt like everything that happened to her could potentially trigger this state of deep thought she'd usually get into.

Among the things she reflected on, there was a memory that lingered a moment too long in her mind; a cherished memory now. The day she met Shadow Weaver, back then Light Spinner. The woman had such a presence, enough to make even a vampire like her feel immediate respect. And

her aroma… she couldn't help recalling how sweet she smelled; it wasn't common for her species to have such honeyed blood…

Unfortunately, she had to brush away this memory as it led to thinking about the taste of that blood and, inevitably, triggered her hunger.

Shaking her head, she began humming a tune to stop her reflections and instead focus solely on her knitting and the music…

Meanwhile, Shadow Weaver was struggling with some experimental potions.

She needed them to work.

She needed this little success as soon as possible.

It was, perhaps, her only chance to restore her wife's health…

She'd always pretend to be trying to restore her own powers and health but, in truth, she didn't care anymore. Potions were enough for her. And she'd rather forfeit even this if it helped her convince Castaspella of how ridiculous her oath is.

Well, maybe not ridiculous, but her stubbornness… If only she changed her oath just a bit… But with the reason behind her oath, she'd never accept even the tiniest change.

She'd sooner die than drink blood again… Especially Shadow Weaver's blood.

So these potions were her last hope of saving her: either they managed to hide the smell and taste of blood so she could at least sneak some into Castaspella's food, or they served as artificial blood to help her recover both her health and her powers.

Perhaps she wasn't the greatest sorceress out there, but it was notorious how much her magic had decayed; the simplest of spells would usually fail, and terribly drain Castaspella as if she were performing magic for the first time in her life.

Without thinking much about it, Shadow Weaver cut her hand open and let a few drops of blood fall on the mix of ingredients in front of her. She then used a healing potion to close the wound so Castaspella wouldn't notice, and tested its efficiency by means of a simple trick she had used multiple times before…

There was a pipe that connected the lounge and the workshop, so she only had to unseal it, blow some of the potion in front of the pipe mouth, and wait for Castaspella's reaction.

Unfortunately for Shadow Weaver, it wasn't long before her wife was knocking on the door asking if she had cut with something again…

That night, they had made plans to go together to the opera, and began preparing early so they could also have dinner out before the play began.

They liked to dress in unconventional ways, and tried to alternate and use either dress or suit each.

This time, it was Castaspella's turn to use a suit, and she opted for a red wine one that actually belonged to Shadow Weaver.

—Does it look good on me?— she asked, before choosing a tie to put on.

—It's a little long for you, I believe. But that's because I'm taller…

—You need to stop bragging about your height…

—I wasn't, I just explained why the suit is too long for you— she replied, unamused. —Maybe if you fold back the sleeves and the hem of the trousers…

As she said that, she knelt to help her with it, and Castaspella let out a fond smile.

—Thank you.

Once finished, Shadow Weaver stood up and smirked.

—Now, you're only missing the tie. Can I?

—Only if you let me help you with the gown afterwards— her wife negotiated.

—Sounds fair to me…

—Good then!

She should have known the woman would choose a black tie, since that's what she would wear…

And after helping her put it on, it was time for Castaspella to pick out a gown for Shadow Weaver.

—Are we going full reverse?— she asked when her wife picked a dark blue dress with golden details.

—I think it's fitting…

—Fair enough. But I'm *not* using heels with that.

—Aw… Why!?

—Because it's raining!

—True enough— Castaspella laughed.

After a hearty dinner, the couple enjoyed a beautiful drama at the opera and, as it drew to a close, they stood up to applaud along with the rest of the audience. Finally, when the lights were turned on again, they gathered their bearings and left the box.

They always bought tickets for the same box, on the middle level, towards the right, near the center. It was implicit that if a vampire had their eye on a box, it was to be considered almost exclusively theirs, unless another vampire wished to take it. But in the past hundred years since the opera opened, no one had attempted to take Castaspella's box.

However, this time around they should have settled for the stalls…

On their way downstairs, Shadow Weaver had to catch her wife before she fell, as she seemed to have suddenly lost balance. It was another symptom of her deteriorating health.

—Wait, wait. Sit for a moment— she pleaded, guiding her closer to the wall. —Are you alright?

—Just a bit dizzy, you needn't worry— Castaspella assured her with a forced smile.

—Don't lie to me, Es.

—I'm not lying…

—Listen: if you aren't feeling well, we can just…

—No— she quickly interrupted. —You're not teleporting us back.

—Then the only option is…

—Don't even say it— Castaspella interrupted again. —For the last time: I only need a minute to rest and we can continue— she sentenced, severe.

—Alright— Shadow Weaver sighed, defeated.

The women sat together for a moment, heads resting against each other, occasionally had to assure those passing by that they were fine, and after perhaps half an hour, they could finally reach the ground level and return home.

It wasn't the first time, nor would it be the last time, that Castaspella had such a serious relapse. By now, it was a well-known fact within the vampire society, and hardly no one was surprised anymore.

It was simple logic: as long as a vampire continued to move around and carry out all manner of activities, drinking blood would be a necessity; the only way to survive with minimal consumption was to cease all activities and sleep uninterrupted.

But Castaspella still went to work with Shadow Weaver, even used sorcery on occasions, and pretended to be alright. She ignored the hunger, the thirst, and ate large portions of normal food as if it were enough; it worried everyone around her.

Her "niece", Glimmer, rarely visited her but always saw her at the academy, both during classes and sometimes during breaks. Yet that only made her deterioration far more notorious than it was for Shadow Weaver.

Her "brother", Micah, tried to see her at least twice a week, to have a drink and chat for a while. Since Glimmer's concern only grew, he began visiting her three or four days a week, usually going to her mansion so she wouldn't have to leave the house.

However, their attempts at convincing her to drink just a drop of blood were for naught. The more everyone around her pushed the matter, the more aggressive she became. Of course, being calm and

collected by nature, she only cut the conversation short each time and politely asked them to leave her alone; yet it became more and more irritating, and she started raising her voice.

That was when they knew they had pushed too far.

It was the middle of the week, and right as Glimmer arrived at the academy, she saw Castaspella and Shadow Weaver slowly walking in, hand in hand…

She noticed how they were careful to keep what little exposed skin the vampire had well under the shadow of the parasol Castaspella always carried with her during the day.

It was technically normal, she had seen this plenty of times, but now, something in Shadow Weaver's expression made her think that perhaps sunlight had become more dangerous for her.

She was about to approach them when her friends called her name. Adora, Catra, and Lonnie were shouting from the window of their classroom…

—Hey, guys!— she shouted back, before teleporting directly inside. —Where are Kyle and Bow? — she asked, after looking around and seeing only Rogelio sitting at the back.

—Kyle didn't finish breakfast yet— Adora replied, giggling.

—And your *boyfriend* is running late— Lonnie added, teasingly.

As the three girls giggled, Glimmer tried to hide a blush behind a scowl and complained —Come on! We're graduating this year! How long are you going to keep making fun of us!?

—As long as you get embarrassed, this is funny as heck!— Catra pointed out, still laughing.

She was about to retort when Adora interrupted —Hey, sorry to ask this, but what's the matter with Aunt Casta?

—Why do you keep calling her that? She's not even Sparkles' real aunt— Lonnie reminded her.

—I know…— she admitted, ashamed. —But it feels nice— she argued.

—I mean, Lonnie is right, but I guess I can't blame you for feeling like that either— Glimmer agreed. —And she's still refusing to… you know…

—How long has it been?

—Five years— Catra uttered, arms folded as she looked away, frowning. —Can't believe she's risking her life like that.

—Aww, you care!— Adora chuckled.

—Why-why wouldn't I!? Do you remember what it was like before she arrived?

—Don't remind me— Lonnie begged, shivering. —It would suck terribly if she had to retire and we were left alone with Shadow Weaver the rest of the year.

—Don’t even say it!

At the back of the classroom, Rogelio growled announcing both Kyle and Bow had arrived, only a minute before Castaspella.

—Good morning, Class!— she cheerfully greeted them. —Let’s get ready to begin; everyone, take out your books while we wait for Shadow Weaver to arrive. And while you’re at it, go over chapter six, yes? She’s planning to quiz you before the class starts!

She giggled sheepishly and sat at her usual spot, away from the windows, while everyone rushed to skim through chapter six as indicated.

—Hey, Glim— Bow called in a low tone. —Is she alright?

She shook her head with a sad expression.

Right after, Catra spoke from behind and made them both look back.

—I think we need to talk to her. Maybe she’ll listen to us…

—Not with this— Glimmer lamented.

Before they could say anything else, Castaspella cleared her throat and they all returned to their books.

The class loved her; she really felt like an aunt to them, regardless of whether they did or didn’t literally call her that, as Adora did.

And they wouldn’t dare disobey her.

Not out of fear, however. It was out of preservation instinct.

Her being a vampire was as scary for them as it was for any mortal, but they feared Shadow Weaver even more…

Later that night, Castaspella was alone at home, waiting for her wife to return so they could prepare dinner. As usual, she poured herself a drink and sat to knit for a while; the kids of the academy were no longer little, but they still had to be supervised until bedtime, so it was Shadow Weaver’s responsibility to remain until everyone finished dinner.

Thinking about this made her sigh. She could remember how hard it was to teach the woman to be patient and not rush the kids. Castaspella discovered that she hated being supervised as much as the kids did, so she made her promise she’d give the children their time to finish dinner at their own pace, or she’d have to stay there and supervise her every evening.

It always made her giggle, realizing how hard Shadow Weaver tried to be mean and pretend she didn’t care; at first, she *really* didn’t care, but she had managed to delve into the depths of the woman’s mind, and it was far more complex. After enough talking and reflecting, she had gotten her wife to open up and be honest.

And it always made her wonder…

Castaspella's thoughts were interrupted by a knock on the door, and she left her knitting on the couch to go open.

It couldn't be Shadow Weaver, she had the key, so it inevitably had to be…

—Micah! Good evening!

—Hey, Sis— he replied, forcing half a smile. It seemed impossible, but she looked far worse than the last time he saw her, barely two days before. —Are you alone?

—Yes. Bea has yet to return— she replied, letting him in. —Would you like a drink?

—Yes, please.

She smiled and gracefully went into the kitchen to fetch him something. Meanwhile, he took a seat on the individual couch next to the lounge where Castaspella had left her knitting, and let out a long sigh.

—Here— she said, handing him a round glass. —I suppose you're here because of your daughter, am I right?

—Ho-how did you know?— he uttered, shocked, stopping right before taking a sip.

—Glimmer and her friends sometimes forget how good my hearing is— she casually replied, returning to her knitting.

—I see— he sighed. After a long sip, he finally admitted —Well then, you already know it's not just Glimmer and I worried about your health…

—Micah, no matter how many times or how hard you try to convince me, I am not breaking my oath— she reminded him. —I don't want to invite you to leave already so, please, let's change subjects.

—Alright— he accepted, lowering his head and sighing again, defeated. —In that case, I… wanted to thank you— he told her, looking back at her again with a sad smile.

—What for?

—Treating Glimmer and I like family— he clarified.

—I should thank you for that…

—I-I mean, I know why you- I know that- Ah… What I'm trying to say is that you *really* treat us like family, not like substitutes for the family you lost, but rather like a new family— he stammered. —I won't lie and say I always felt like I was missing something, but I can tell you I really like having someone I can call my "sister", and *feel* it. And, at the same time, I appreciate that you never tried to push me to be the ghost of the Micah you knew— he went on. —As for Glimmer, and even her friends at the Academy, she says they are all very fond of you; you've really won them over— he told her with a smile. —And I need to *stop* saying "really"— he laughed. —But I mean it, alright? We care a lot about you, and I wanted you to know that and to thank you for giving us the chance to be in your life without trying to make us fit into the spots left behind by our… previous incarnations.

Castaspella put her knitting down again and grabbed her glass. After a short sip, she let out a sigh and smiled faintly.

—It's strange hearing a human speaking about the matter, you know— she commented. —But I guess it's normal for someone in your position to be privy to this kind of information.

—I may have asked Angella too many questions— he admitted, scratching the back of his neck. —I just… Well, I feel like that's something I should know about. Hasn't Light- erm, Shadow Weaver asked questions?

—Not really. I think she purposely stirs away from the matter whenever the conversation heads towards that inevitable question.

—So she doesn't know anything about her previous incarnation?

—No.

—Or your relationship?

—No.

—She never asked why you interfered back when I was a teen?

—Of course she did… But hasn't since we became friends; I must admit I expected her to ask again after we married, but she didn't— Castaspella explained. —Like I said, I think she does it on purpose.

—But she knows that you basically adopted me as a brother because I'm his reincarnation?

—Yes.

—That's… weird.

—Not with her. Knowing Beatrix, she's waiting for me to speak about it first, when I'm ready.

—Are you?

—I don't know.

—Are you afraid of what she may think?

—I wouldn't say I'm *afraid*. But I have to admit I'm not looking forward to retelling my life story.

—Why?

—Micah… I'm a thousand years old yet I threw away more than half of that time. I certainly don't like retelling my life solely to realize how little I've lived— she explained.

—Bu-but… you don't need to think about it that way!

—How else am I supposed to look at it?

—Well, for instance, Angella is six thousand years old, right?— he began, and she nodded. —Well, when you ask her about her life, she has far less than me to tell. But you wouldn't say she did

nothing in all that time, would you?

—She chooses not to tell us, Micah. It's different— she countered. —I spent hundreds of years just sleeping, grieving, doing *literally* nothing— she reminded him. —I don't have anything to tell, even if I wanted to.

—Well, I disagree, Sis. I know you traveled all over the world over the last hundreds of years— he argued. —Maybe nothing notorious happened, but I'm sure you have a lot to say about those trips.

—Micah…

—I mean it— he insisted. —So, if what you fear is that Shadow Weaver will think you wasted most of your life, then let me assure you, she won't. Stars! She loves you so much she'd probably go on a rant about this to convince you!

—Probably calling me a fool while at it— Castaspella laughed.

He chuckled and finished his glass before standing up with a sigh.

—Alright. I should get going— he finally said. —I promised Glimmer I'd try, and I did…

—I think I'll talk to her and the other kids tomorrow…

—Just remember they care— Micah pointed out.

—Of course.

She stood up too, walked him to the door, and waited instead of opening, as she could already hear Shadow Weaver on the other side searching for the keys.

—Did I catch you leaving?— she said with a smirk, flawlessly hiding her surprise.

—Good evening for you too— Micah replied, rolling his eyes.

—Come on, Bea…

—Alright, alright. *Good evening*— she condescendingly said as she walked inside. —Can I go prepare dinner already?

—Make sure it's well seasoned— Micah commented, chuckling, with a foot already outside.

—Don't you dare sneak a single drop of blood into the food. I can smell it immediately— Castaspella severely stated, almost pushing him outside but looking back at Shadow Weaver.

—Trust me, I know— her wife replied. —I already tried.

Their dinner was brief, as both were quite tired and wanted to go to sleep as soon as possible, yet Castaspella managed to squeeze a bit of conversation in the ten minutes it took them to empty their plates.

—Can I ask you something?

—Sure.

—Do you ever wonder anything about…

—About?

—Well, about my life before meeting you? Or even about my life before becoming a vampire?

—Of course.

—Why don't you ask?

—Why don't you tell me?

—I-I mean, I don't know what you would like to know, and I'm not going to start talking about that stuff unprompted…

—Would you answer now any question I make?

—Perhaps?

—Then it's not the right time yet— Shadow Weaver stated, returning to her food.

—I see… I think I understand.

—I'll be more than glad to hear you out once you're ready— she immediately assured her, smiling a bit.

They soon finished and washed the dishes together, eager to finally go to bed.

The following day, Castaspella struggled to wake up, and even more so to get up. Groaning lowly, she dragged herself into the bathroom and almost fell asleep again there.

Shadow Weaver found her falling over the washbasin, water running, and let out a long sigh.

What a handful…

Once dressed and sat in front of the table, Castaspella woke up again, confounded beyond words.

—Ho-how did I get this coffee? I'm- When did I get dressed!? Wasn't I in the bathroom?— she blurted out.

—You were… you fell asleep there— Shadow Weaver replied, casually sitting next to her with her own mug of coffee. —And to answer your other questions, I gave you the coffee, and also dressed you…

—Bea…

—I know. But do *you* know what this means?

—Of course— she had to admit, looking down into her coffee. —Do I look too bad?

—Enough that anyone can tell, yes.

—I'll be fine— she assured her with a smile.

—You're certainly doing a great job of pretending to be fine— Shadow Weaver let out, rolling her eyes.

—As long as I can pretend, then I'm fine enough— her wife replied, taking a sip of her coffee. —Worry when I can no longer pretend.

—I worry already! We all do, Esmeralda!

—Well, you shouldn't.

—Es, I'm begging you: I'd rather give away my blood than lose you!

—Bea…

—Just a bit of blood, you can drink just… a hundred milliliters each month, at the very least, and I promise it won't affect me— Shadow Weaver pleaded. —You already *look* older than me!

—I *am* far older…

—You were turned when you were fifteen years *younger* than I currently am!

—Ho-how do you know that!?

—Micah may have mentioned it— she admitted, looking away in shame as she realized her mistake.

—Well, wrong. It's around ten years, for now— she first corrected. —What else has he told you?— Castaspella severely asked.

—Not much.

—Beatrix!

—Not much! He said I'm supposed to learn it from you!

—Why are you asking *him* about my past!?

—I was not! He let it slip… I didn't ask. I don't want to- I just want to wait until *you* are ready to talk about this with me— Shadow Weaver explained.

—Fine, fine— Castaspella sighed, trying to calm down. —I don't want to argue with you now— she said, shaking her head. —I have to talk with the kids today, so… why don't we also talk later tonight?

—Are you sure?

—Yes. There won't be a "good time", so I'd rather just… do it all while I dare— she replied, resting back on her chair.

—Alright— Shadow Weaver agreed, standing up. She waited a moment for Castaspella to finish her coffee, then picked up the mug, and kissed her on top of her head before washing both cups.

Soon after, the couple was on its way to the academy…

When the first recess of the day was about to begin, they both exchanged a glance and nodded in agreement.

—If you don't mind…— Castaspella began. —I would like to have a short chat with you all before letting you leave the classroom.

—Good, because we also wanna talk to you— Catra immediately retorted, folding her arms and leaning back on her chair.

—Hey…— Adora called her, reproaching. —Be nice…

—I am aware, Catra. I *heard you* yesterday— Castaspella pointed out, her tone severe but her smile gentle. —I hope I don't have to remind you all the various skills we vampires have, so we can skip that part— she began.

—Yeah, let's just get into why you look worse each day.

—Catra!

—Face it, Adora! She does!

—But don't say it like that!

—Guys!— Glimmer interrupted. —Can we let Auntie speak!?

—Sorry…— they both apologized.

Castaspella quickly glanced a Shadow Weaver and noticed she was on the brink of rage; if Glimmer hadn't stopped them, the woman would have…

—I understand your concern. And that's why I wanted to have this moment— she started again. —Of course, if any of you want to go to recess right now, I won't stop you.

After a moment of silence, Kyle gestured dismissively and confidently said —Nah, recess can wait.

—Yeah, what he said— Lonnie agreed, smirking.

The seven students nodded while expressing their agreement, making Castaspella smile wholeheartedly.

—Thank you— she said. —In that case, I want to begin by explaining why I look so ill…

—That's because you aren't drinking blood— Catra interrupted.

—That's correct, but there's a reason for it.

—You mean that promise or oath, or whatever?— the girl insisted. —We know about it too! Five years already, right?

—My Stars…— Castaspella sighed. —Yes, that's correct.

—Why would you do something like that?— she asked, indignant.

—Catra… I know it sounds crazy for you all, but I have my reasons… and I will do my best to make you all understand too— she calmly explained.

—If it ends up being something cheesy, I'm gonna scream.

—Catra…

Castaspella couldn't help letting out a dainty laugh from the bottom of her heart. It was almost contagious and some of the students giggled too. From her desk, Shadow Weaver had been staring the whole time, and even sighed while smiling fondly for a second.

As soon as she realized, she composed herself and sat straight, hoping no one had noticed.

—Recess isn't eternal…— she pointed out.

—Right, I'm sorry— Castaspella apologized. —I'm sorry to say it may sound a bit cheesy after all…

—Just say it, Es.

—Alright— she decided, taking a deep breath. —For those of you who aren't aware, I have over a thousand years.

—That's a lot— Kyle muttered.

—It is— she replied, smirking.

—You heard that!?

—Maybe you did have to go over vampire skills after all— Lonnie mockingly said, making everyone laugh.

—So-sorry— he apologized, scratching his neck a bit ashamed.

—It's quite alright— she gently told him. —The important thing is that, after so much time, I can say for sure that our understanding of life and death, health and illness… it changes quite a lot. And, for someone like me, both death and illness became meaningless.

—Until recently— Shadow Weaver grumbled.

—Bea…

—Am I wrong?

—As I was saying…— Castaspella went on, rolling her eyes. —Death and illness are meaningless to vampires, as we remain immortal as long as we drink blood. But… immortality isn't the reason

why we… do that. I believe you all are old enough to understand what blood-thirst is.

—Yeah, but that only makes it even more confusing that you would *decide* to suffer the consequences of not drinking blood while also fighting the thirst— Bow pointed out.

—I imagine. However…— Castaspella was replying, when Shadow Weaver cleared her throat. —What?

—Stop digressing.

—Oh, Stars. You're impossible.

—Just *say it*.

—Ugh! If you dislike my way of saying it, then explain it yourself!— she finally grunted, folding her arms.

Her mind immediately went to an almost forgotten moment of her past, and she felt a pang of pain in the middle of her chest upon realizing it.

You said I could do it!

You were taking too long…

Different circumstances, different words… same feeling.

—In short, five years ago she freaked out when I fainted and thought it was because she had drank my blood earlier that day— Shadow Weaver briefly explained. —Even though I've told her plenty of times that was *not* the case…

—That was the final drop! I needed only *one* last reason to finally swear never to drink blood again; so you can claim as much as you want that you passed out for different reasons, but I know what the doctor said, and you needed a transfusion to wake up!— Castaspella exclaimed, raising her voice a bit, and speaking severely. Then, realizing it, she took a deep breath, lowered her voice to her normal tone, and concluded —So, in summary, as a consequence, I made an oath never to drink blood, any blood, ever again. And I accept the consequences. If it means I'll lose my immortality, then so be it. I can't say I didn't have a long life…

—But haven't you considered you aren't just dooming yourself to death, but rather… that you may continue to live in agony for who-knows-how-long?— Glimmer asked, concerned.

—Yeah, what Sparkles said— Lonnie agreed. —If such thirst is anything like insomnia, for example, then it could even drive you mad…

At the back, Rogelio growled in agreement and Kyle nodded. Bow and Adora exchanged a worried look, and then noticed that Catra was looking at the ground, expression somber, and fist tightly closed.

She was about to explode.

—You can't be serious!— she yelled. But not at Castaspella, she was glaring at Shadow Weaver. —Are you *listening*!? Did you *know* all of that!?

—I have lived the past five years seeing her get worse and worse with each passing day!— the woman immediately replied with the same tone, slamming her hands on the desk as she stood up.

—Then how can you just *let it happen*!?

—"Just let it happen"!? What on Etheria do you mean!? You have no idea everything I've been doing this whole time!

—Clearly not enough!

—Silence!— Shadow Weaver ordered, with a tone that sent goosebumps all over them. —You dare speak about things you don't know about!?

—Beatrix— Castaspella called, without moving a single inch. Her voice was commanding despite the tone remaining normal. —Don't make me say it.

—But…

—*But* it doesn't mean you can speak like that.

—So she gets to say whatever but…

—Don't finish that sentence. You sound like a child— Castaspella quickly interrupted her. —Catra is a teenager; she has a lot to learn about respect, boundaries, and such matters. What is *your* excuse?— she asked, head tilted to the side as she imitated that condescending tone her wife *loved* to use.

—So now you mock me?— Shadow Weaver growled.

—If that's what it takes to make you see you're overreacting…

—Would you rather I didn't care?— she rebuked.

—I think this is enough.

—Of course you do…— the woman sneered, looking away with her arms crossed in front of her chest.

—Well, kids, I think this was enough for you too. Better go enjoy what's left of the break and we'll return for the next period a few minutes later, yes?— Castaspella sentenced, ushering them all out of the classroom.

Shadow Weaver silently waited behind her wife until all the students were out; once the door was closed, she bitterly asked —Is this the part where we argue and you threaten to sleep in a different room tonight?

—I hoped this was the part where you reflect on what just happened and realize it was an overreaction.

—That *insolent* girl was…

—Let me stop you right there— Castaspella interrupted, turning around and raising a hand in a halting gesture. —Why do you always call Catra "disrespectful" or any of its synonyms but then

behave just in the same manner? I wasn't trying to mock you, I really mean it when I say she's just a teenager. The one who should be an example, is *you*! Not even me, I'm just a professor assistant.

—They even call you "aunt"— Shadow Weaver pointed out.

—But the mother figure here is *you*. And you're not doing a great job at that…

—Thanks for the *constant* reminder— she sneered.

—I only say it because I need you to understand how important you are to them. The way you treat them, the way you talk to them, the vocabulary you use… it all has a great impact in their development.

—Yes, yes. You've only mentioned that about a hundred times…

—But you still don't get it!

—I am *trying*!

—I know you are— Castaspella sighed, looking away. —And I know it's difficult… But just trying isn't enough. Do you understand what I say and why I say it?

—I do! And it's enraging!— Shadow Weaver cried out, grabbing her hair with both hands.

Castaspella immediately stopped her from pulling her hair, and tried to soothe her.

—Why does it make you so angry?

—It feels *unfair*! How can I allow someone so respectless to speak in such a way and do nothing!?

—But that's where you're wrong— Castaspella interrupted, gently lowering her wife's hands and taking a step closer. —Did I say she wasn't disrespectful? No. I said *your reaction* was exaggerated, immature.

—I cannot control my reactions!

—And that's the problem we're trying to fix, alright? I believe you can control them. Don't you *want* to be in control?

—Of course— Shadow Weaver sighed, looking away.

—Then let me help you.

—What else is there to do? You've tried everything, haven't you!?

—But have *you* tried? Or have you just told me what I wanted to hear and then dismissed my words?

—I have tried. I swear…

—Then, please, don't give up just yet— Castaspella pleaded. —I… can't tell you why yet, but I can say the effort is noticeable; those kids… they fear you, but they aren't traumatized— she explained,

looking away briefly. —I saw no fear in Catra's eyes when she confronted you today. And that is *good*.

—Doesn't sound "good" to me— Shadow Weaver muttered, folding her arms and looking away with a frown.

—If she were afraid, she would have still spoken in the same way, probably even worse, but there would have been visible fear in her eyes, and all her body language.

—Am I supposed to…

—Don't say anything— Castaspella stopped her. —You aren't "supposed to" *anything*. Just, trust my words for now. Tonight we'll talk, and I'll also try to explain what I meant just now.

—Alright— her wife huffed, rolling her eyes.

—Thank you— she smiled. —The kids must be about to return, so…

Her words were cut short by Shadow Weaver's sudden kiss. She giggled while kissing her back for a moment.

—You better keep being this insufferable the rest of our lives… and never allow me to become the monster I believe myself to be— the woman sighed as soon as their lips parted.

—Deal— she giggled.

When classes finished for the day, Glimmer and Bow left together shortly before Castaspella. Shadow Weaver was left alone with the five orphans until dinner time was over, but this time, she was… suspiciously silent.

She made no unnecessary negative comments, as she *so* liked to do, nor did she answer them in that condescending manner of hers when addressed.

Kyle even spoke to her for a long while, enough to annoy Rogelio, who growled at him to stop, but the woman just remained silent, occasionally nodding or rolling her eyes, yet uttered no word.

Eventually, Catra and Adora decided to try their luck, only to get the most concise and brisk replies from her. Not snarls, not growls. Just quick, short, and cold retorts.

They couldn't know, but this was her *trying* even harder than normal.

The logic? If she had nothing nice to say, then she wouldn't say a thing.

And if it was completely necessary to answer, then she'd only speak the bare minimum in the most neutral way.

She had no idea how to be *nice*, but she knew how to be mean; all she could do for now, she thought, was to refrain from being nasty, and that was the result.

That night, when she left the academy, her head hurt and she felt depleted of energy. But there was something on her mind she couldn't wait to tell her wife about…

—Welcome back— Castaspella greeted her when she walked into the kitchen. —Everything alright after I left?

—They said "good night"— Shadow Weaver uttered, supporting herself on the door frame. —I thought it was a joke but…

—What are you talking about?— her wife asked, confused. She dried her hands after finishing with the dishes and approached the woman. —Are you alright? You look pale…

—Es, they- the kids… They wished me goodnight before I left! *Why*!?— she repeated, grabbing Castaspella's arms and shaking her slightly. —At first, it was just Kyle and I thought he was mocking me, but… the five of them…

—Did anything happen during dinner?— she gently asked with a soft look.

—I didn't do anything! I barely spoke!

—Alright, alright. Calm down, my Love. This is something *good*— Castaspella told her, while guiding her to take a seat at the table. —Did you answer?

—No.

—Why?

—I didn't know what to say…

—What would you answer me if I said "good night"?

—Do I ever answer?

—That's why I'm asking. You never do, only…

—Kiss you. I don't know what to answer to someone who is *not* my partner.

—Oh my Stars, Beatrix… Sometimes your mind can be very complicated…

—I only turned off the lights and left. *What* could I possibly answer!?

—With how angry you sound, maybe it was for the best that you didn't answer— Castaspella reflected. —But we need to work on that.

—Look, I was really trying to do what you told me. I was… *not* being mean. I didn't make unnecessary comments. Everything you've told me. And this happens!?

—Wait, so you…

—I said I would try, didn't I?

—Yes, and I'm sure it was quite difficult for you— Castaspella replied, now a bit concerned. —I'm starting to think that, perhaps… the kids noticed it? So what they did, wishing you goodnight

before you left… it was an act of kindness from them. They were being nice to you because they recognized your effort to… not be mean.

—That's ridiculous…

—You're stubborn…

—Alright, I get it. I don't understand simple kindness or something— Shadow Weaver huffed, rolling her eyes. —Can we prepare dinner already?

—I should leave you to starve tonight for that… but I'm not *you*— Castaspella mocked her. —Come on, let's start cooking. We have a lot to discuss after dinner— she finally decided.

—Why not while we eat?

—I rather you don't choke on your food nor let it go cold…

—Fair enough— Shadow Weaver sighed.

Dinner lasted less than half an hour, as usual, and both washed the dishes together afterwards. They acted as if there was no heavy topic to discuss and followed their normal evening routine.

Only when both lay down in bed, did the silence become unbearable.

—Well… Whenever you want… Ask away— Castaspella offered.

—What are you willing to tell me about?

—Everything. I just… don't know where to begin.

—Then why don't we start with your turning?— Shadow Weaver suggested, laying on her side to look at her wife. —I know what everyone else is taught in History lessons about that time, but what exactly happened that *you* ended up becoming a vampire?

—I guess that's a good place to begin. But you'll need some context then…

—Fine by me. We have all night.

Castaspella closed her eyes and sighed. Her left hand reached for her wife and Shadow Weaver didn't hesitate to hold it between hers.

—A thousand years ago, Etheria was quite different. We had been at war since before I was born, against a faction known as "the Horde". The leader was Hordak, whom we knew as some alien who appeared one day and began a campaign to conquer our world, and… the rulers formed a resistance called "the Princess Alliance". That much you know, right?

—Yes. And the leader was Angella, until the apparition of the legendary hero, She-Ra.

—Did you know "She-Ra" was a regular teen who hailed from the Horde?

—Not exactly…

—How much do you know about reincarnation?— Castaspella decided to ask, now looking back at her.

—Why the change of subject?

—It's related, I promise.

—I only know it as a theory…

—Then let me tell you: it's a fact.

—Everyone reincarnates after a thousand years?

—*Almost* everyone, yes.

—Before you go on… Did you meet my previous incarnation?

—Yes.

—Did we meet before or after you were turned?

—Before…

—Was it… my fault?— Shadow Weaver then asked, feeling a sudden void in her chest.

—No.

—You don't need to sugarcoat things for me.

—I don't intend to— Castaspella assured her. —I'll tell you everything.

—Alright.

—When I met Shadow Weaver, I had been hating her for years— she began. —All I knew was that she had been my brother's tutor, back when she was known as Light Spinner, and that she put him in danger. Could have gotten him killed…

—Sounds familiar…

—I was something around thirty-five or thirty-six when I first met her… and she was dying— she explained, looking away. —After decades of using and abusing the power she got from the parasitic magic she summoned… after decades of using that power to help the Horde, she had escaped and demanded to see one of her former wards from the Horde. Adora.

—Hold on, I'm confused… You mean… the previous reincarnation of Adora, my student…

—All the orphans of the Academy are reincarnations of orphans from the Horde. All of them were wards under Shadow Weaver's care— Castaspella interrupted.

—Why?

—It's just how history is supposed to go.

—But you… have been trying to change it.

—I've been trying to *influence* it— she clarified. She then turned on her side to look directly at her wife and explained —Listen: *you* are not *her*. Like the Micah you know is not *my* Micah. A thousand years ago, I met a woman who deeply traumatized my brother when he was a teen, and then deeply scarred the kids under her care at the Horde. I met a woman who was bitter, manipulative, and treacherous. If the situation hadn't been dire, I may have never given her a chance. But I did. Let me tell you this story, and maybe you'll understand everything I've done since we met.

—Alright.

—When I met Shadow Weaver, she was dying; she was also a prisoner in Bright Moon, and I was supposed to help interrogate her. However, she kept getting on our nerves and it was impossible to make her speak. When she finally did, however, all on her terms, of course, she told us that the Horde we had struggled with for so long was *nothing* compared to what was coming.

—Horde Prime?

—Exactly. Hordak eventually managed to call him… a lot of things happened… and before we knew it, we had been invaded. And that was when we learnt something about Hordak we had no idea about: he was a vampire— Castaspella revealed.

—How didn't you know?

—He had never acted like it. No one ever heard of him sucking blood or anything that could remotely make us infer he was a vampire.

—Then, what changed?

—Horde Prime's arrival caused panic, but not as much as the first Etherian who, after being captured, returned as a mindless vampire— she replied, somber. —Perhaps "mindless" isn't the right word. It was more like, there was a hive mind controlled by Prime, and anyone he turned, was immediately attached to it.

—The books…

—Don't tell everything.

—Alright, excuse me. Go on— Shadow Weaver apologized, slightly ashamed.

—Patience, my Love— Castaspella muttered, caressing her cheek. —When the invasion began, things were more or less like this: Angella was gone and Glimmer had to step up as Queen, but was abducted as soon as Prime's ship appeared; my brother, whom we thought had died years before, was found at Beast Island and returned home safe, the exact same moment Glimmer was being abducted; She-Ra, who was Adora, I forgot to say, lost the sword that she had been using to transform, but I can't tell you de details because it's a whole different story I don't remember quite well.

—I think I follow…

—Good. The Rebellion of the Princess Alliance was… in shambles, to be honest, because we had been terribly overwhelmed by Hordak and Catra before Prime's arrival— she went on.

—Catra?

—Yes. She remained at the Horde despite Adora leaving, and became quite a fierce enemy after Shadow Weaver left too.

—Who would have thought…

—Stars, please don't… you sound just like her.

—I just can't believe a child of that age could possibly be a powerful enemy.

—All thanks to Shadow Weaver's *excellent* fosterage.

—You're being sarcastic…

—Obviously— Castaspella replied, rolling her eyes. —That woman pushed her to her limit, and not in a good way. She *broke* her.

—Which you're trying to avoid now…

—Yeah… you could say that…

—Alright, just go on…

—Well, the thing is, Catra was abducted along with Glimmer and Hordak, so both the biggest threats to Etheria and the Queen were suddenly gone— she started again. —To make it short, Adora, Bow, and Princess Entrapta organized a mission to rescue Glimmer, and left Etheria for quite a long time. I only have a faint idea of what happened out there, and meanwhile, we were being attacked by robots far more advanced than the ones Hordak would send against us…

—And the clone vampires appeared later?

—Yes. It was just robots at first, that either destroyed things or captured people. I think a day or so *before* the mission from space returned, the first vampires appeared.

—I'm not following…

—I'm sorry, I'll try to be clearer— Castaspella apologized, looking away. She loosely wrapped her arms around Shadow Weaver and reformulated —The kids, Glimmer, Bow, Adora, and Catra, along with Princess Entrapta, were in space for a week or so. Something happened, in Prime's ship, and they returned with both Catra and a vampire clone *on our side*. But shortly before their return, one of the captured Etherians of whom we had heard nothing since their disappearance, showed up at the Rebellion hideout claiming they didn't remember what happened.

—It was a lie.

—Exactly. They had been turned into a vampire, and were part of Horde Prime's hive mind, so the robots soon found the hideout— she explained. —I was in Mystacor when they told me Micah had been captured, so I rushed there only to find… almost no one remained. Some of the princesses and… Shadow Weaver.

—You say it like it's a bad thing.

—I believed it was at the time…

—I don't think I'll like the reason.

—Bea, you're not her. I am talking about a woman I barely knew back then. In fact, it turns out that all I *thought* I knew about her, up to that moment, was mostly fake…

Shadow Weaver sighed and shook her head.

—Don't worry, just go on…

—Basically, I arrived at a ravaged camp and was *very* angry to learn that Micah had been abducted but Shadow Weaver, of all people, hadn't. Yet she ignored my attitude and didn't hesitate to ask for my help to save Micah before he, too, was turned into a vampire— she resumed. —I didn't have a plan or options, so I decided to give her the benefit of the doubt and followed her through the woods while the others went to find a new hideout.

—But you didn't trust her.

—Not in the least. Or, well, I kept telling myself it had to be a trap of some sort… Eventually, I exploded, made a lot of accusations, and she proved many of my beliefs about her were wrong… very wrong— Castaspella replied. —She showed me I had been manipulated by the Sorcerers Guild, and then offered me a deal: I would help her get the means to free Micah before it was too late, we'd free Etheria's magic to defeat Horde Prime… And, if she tried to take the power for herself, I would do *anything* necessary to stop her.

—What does that mean?

—You really want to know?

The woman sighed, thinking more carefully about it, and said —Better go on…

—It took us a few days but we found that there was a way to free the magic that the First Ones had been storing within the core of Etheria. Please don't ask me what that was or how that worked. Just… know it was some ancient contraption for which we discovered a "failsafe" to get rid of it— Castaspella explained.

—I read about the Heart of Etheria…

—Good. Then I'll go on— she sighed, closing her eyes. —What no one knows, what doesn't appear in any books, is that the failsafe had to be taken by a willing soul. But Shadow Weaver didn't tell me, or anyone, everything about it until we had sneaked into Mystacor to get it; right there and then, we learnt that only Adora had a *chance* to survive, and that if anyone else took the failsafe, they would surely die.

—Fine, fine. I suppose I also tend to withhold crucial information too…— the woman admitted, rolling her eyes.

—Oh, shut up— Castaspella giggled, before planting a kiss on her forehead. —You have learnt to trust me enough that, if it had been *you*, I know you would have told me.

—I think so… But I don't know what her reasons were.

—Well, it doesn't really matter because, when we were all calling her out on her bullshit, Horde Prime himself showed up, dragging Micah, semiconscious.

—What!?

—He… used him as leverage. Horde Prime could access anyone's memories without necessarily turning them, so he knew neither Glimmer, Shadow Weaver, nor I would act against him as long as Micah's life was on the line— she explained. —But that wasn't the case for Bow and Catra, who didn't hesitate to attack.

—Let me guess… this ends with you turned…

—Kind of— she admitted. —What happened then was a mess. Adora took the chance to go for the Failsafe now that Catra wasn't stopping her. Glimmer quickly joined her friends and told me to get Micah, so I dragged Shadow Weaver to help me. But when I managed to free his hands and he was almost awake, Prime overwhelmed them and immediately jumped on him— Castaspella explained, somber.

—You got in the way…

—I pushed him aside, Shadow Weaver caught him, and Prime caught *me*.

—Yes, you mentioned before that he had turned you…— her wife recalled, but was surprised when she shook her head.

—He… didn't.

—What?

—He drained me and left me to die.

—You can't be serious… Then *what* happened!?

—I was told… a few things— Castaspella explained. —Apparently, Adora managed to turn into She-Ra last minute, so they all could escape and return to the hideout, carrying both Micah and me. Glimmer told me that Adora and Catra then argued because of the Failsafe, because Adora "chose Shadow Weaver" again, and so Catra left. Then Adora confronted Shadow Weaver, made a lot of accusations… and she… agreed with Adora. Apparently, she had argued with Micah as soon as he was conscious enough, and that made her behave in a completely unexpected way; she accepted everything Adora said about her, admitted she was a bitch, a jerk, a liar, a manipulator, and that she ruins people…— she went on, incredulous. —But then… I can hardly believe it still, but Glimmer says she begged Adora to help me. She promised she would do *anything*, that she would even apologize to Catra if she helped me like she had helped her back when she was dying…

—Ah, yes, you mentioned she was dying when you met her.

—Yes, and She-Ra healed her. But she couldn't heal me— Castaspella sighed. —She told her my only chance was being turned…

—Where did they get a vampire willing to turn you?

—That's a funny question— she giggled. —I told you they returned from space with a vampire clone, right? Unfortunately, that one couldn't help; when Bow and Entrapta found him and

accidentally pulled him from the hive mind, he hadn't even left the… creation pod, or whatever that was… Entrapta wasn't very clear. But, basically, he didn't have vampire blood to turn me. However, it just so happens that Catra hadn't gone that far yet. She heard it all and couldn't believe what Shadow Weaver was saying. Glimmer said Catra *wanted* to help me regardless, but she offered her assistance to capture another clone vampire *if* she apologized to her right there and then — she went on, letting out a laugh. —This part, even Micah had to swear it was true because I couldn't believe it. Shadow Weaver *actually* apologized. It was terrible and she looked in agony, they said it was both tragic and comical… But she did it.

—I hope I never have to do that…

—I hope there won't be a *reason* for you to have to do it— Castaspella retorted, reproaching. —But, back to what happened… guess who they captured.

—I'm guessing Hordak himself?

—Right in one— she nodded.

—Is that why you're so… strange around him?

—I am?

—I always thought it was either respect or fear…

—I don't really know how to feel about him…

—Why don't you tell me how it happened?

—I was told that Hordak was among the other vampire clones when Catra and Shadow Weaver caught him; they chose him because he seemed odd, as if he wasn't part of the hive mind. And they were right, actually. Hordak wasn't fully integrated into the hive mind after Prime abducted him, and he even recalled everything from the time he led the Horde— she explained. —So, apparently, he wasn't cooperating and… Well… When I woke up, with the hideous taste of blood in my mouth, Shadow Weaver was in agony again, like the first time I met her.

—Sounds like she used black magic.

—Exactly.

—That's why you don't want me to use it?

—In short… yes.

—Long answer?

—It's part of the story… So, evidently, she used black magic to force Hordak to turn me, and it worked. But she had exerted herself for decades, you know. Her life was barely extended by She-Ra's power. And…— she began, sighing. —After they told me everything that had happened, I realized I owed Shadow Weaver my new life. We also realized I was the first Etherian who, after being turned, wasn't part of the hive mind!

—Because you were turned by Hordak instead of Prime.

—Exactly.

—But then, what the books say about the vampires turning against Prime…

—That's all thanks to Entrapta— Castaspella smiled. —She analyzed *something* in the vampire clone she and Bow disconnected from the hive mind, and found the way it worked! It was truly amazing— she assured her. —So, as she found the way to disconnect vampires from the hive mind, and as Hordak remembered her from when they worked together in his lab or something, we crafted an alternative plan to defeat Prime without risking Adora's life unnecessarily.

—You… led the uprising of the vampires?— she uttered, looking surprised.

—Along with Hordak and the other vampire clone, we joined Prime's forces pretending to still belong to the hive mind, and began freeing the turned Etherians— she explained. —When we moved on to the other clones, however, their sudden disappearances from the hive mind called his attention and he found us.

—Well, yes. As noble as you might think it was, what you did was pretty reckless. And for people you didn't even know— her wife pointed out.

—I was told that, when Shadow Weaver finally woke up, she said something similar, yes…— Castaspella sighed. —Apparently, Adora and Catra… they saw something in her, a real change of heart, or perhaps that something inside her had broken, and I was told they calmed her down, dissuaded her from going after me, and explained that they three were the backup plan in case we failed… Which we did. But not completely.

—Explain that.

—I'm on it— she nodded. —When Prime realized what we had done, it was vampires against vampires. The bots had all been destroyed already, and the rest of the Etherians were hiding. Bow and Glimmer then let the girls know, and Shadow Weaver helped Adora and Catra reach the Heart — she retold. —They mentioned Prime tried to get in their way, but with our little vampire revolution, so to speak, he couldn't focus on them.

—The books say that She-Ra released the power of the Heart and shone sunlight on Prime and his vampire clones… How did the vampire society survive then?

—Shadow Weaver told me that, when they got to the Heart, she felt a sudden surge of power, and that it was… inebriating. Catra and Adora could barely bring her back to her senses, but when they did, she had some sort of revelation— Castaspella began. —She told Adora that this was She-Ra's full power, that it could command Etheria's magical and natural rebirth. They understood that meant she could get rid of Prime's ship to wipe out all vampires, and Catra pointed out that would also kill the vampires we had been freeing. But Shadow Weaver could feel the power of the Heart and said she would take care of that… And she did.

—How?

—She protected us with her shadows. She kept us all covered, Catra made sure she wouldn't miss anyone, and Adora got rid of Horde Prime and all the hostile vampire clones.

Shadow Weaver remained silent and rested her forehead on Castaspella's chest. She took a couple of deep breaths and nodded.

—So… That Shadow Weaver… what happened with her?

—You want to know whether she was my partner too?

—Something like that…

—Oh, Bea— Castaspella giggled. —Please don't start envying the past…

—I just… need to know.

—You *want to* know.

—Yes, yes, whatever.

—You're terrible— she chuckled, holding her closer. —Yes. Eventually, we became close enough… At first, we were just friends… or whatever that woman would call it… Much to my brother's distraught, I supported her, vouched for her, and while she wasn't pardoned or anything, she was given a chance to make up for all the shit she had done— Castaspella began. —I think it really helped Adora, Catra, and the other kids from the Horde; she hated every moment of it, but she set an example for the former Horde soldiers. She never really made peace with Hordak, but at least they both agreed on something: they owed Etheria a lot. She asked me to supervise her, like Entrapta promised to supervise Hordak, and Queen Glimmer officially gave them a set of duties they were expected to fulfill from then on.

—Like?

—Well, I don't know what Hordak was ordered to do, but Shadow Weaver had to use what remained of her power for good deeds: helping people rebuild, providing healing potions when required, helping us teach sorcery again… I was still the Head Sorceress, you know— Castaspella replied.

—Wait… something doesn't make sense: the books say the Vampire Society remained hidden for decades— the woman pointed out.

—Yes, that's true. Only some people from the Rebellion knew about my… condition.

—Then how did you feed?

—Shadow Weaver helped with that— she sighed. —I didn't really like the taste of blood, even if I had the insatiable thirst… She blamed herself for what happened to me and offered to help me feed without anyone knowing— she explained. —It worked better than expected because, between my distaste for it in general, and the awful taste of her corrupted blood, I never developed an addiction to it, so to speak…

—Why was it so… awful? You never said my blood…

—No, no. It's different— Castaspella quickly interrupted. —Shadow Weaver had spent decades wearing herself out, abusing the power of the parasite, letting it overtake her, and using black magic until her corruption became irreversible— she briefly clarified. —You can consider this to be part of why I don't want you to use either black magic or the power of the parasite…

—I suppose it makes sense…

—So… Shadow Weaver eventually became… my *best* friend; I got to know her, I could trust her, I could always depend on her… And after something about a decade, our relationship developed into something more.

—A decade after Prime's defeat?

—Yes, exactly. She helped me hide my vampire nature, gave me the idea of using illusions to look older and retire, allowing someone else to be head of the Sorcerers Guild, and then we built this place… With help, a lot of help— she went on. —We lived here together, alone like you and me now, for another decade until Entrapta managed the impossible: a functioning interdimensional portal. Glimmer, Bow, Adora, and Catra had been working with her on it for so long… And they finally managed it. That way, they could bring Angella back to our dimension— she recalled. —There was a lot of catching up to do, and she was… quite baffled to learn there was now a whole secret society of immortals like her. Or… not-that-much like her…

—The books say she dictated the vampires' integration into society… But, if my mathematics are correct, that began about a decade later— her wife commented.

—Yes, that would be correct. But… what triggered that…— Castaspella replied, interrupting herself with a sigh. —It was Micah's death.

—What?

—His dying wish was to help me return to society. I had been living under the name Esmeralda for a while, and was known as some sort of recluse of the Whispering Woods…— she explained. —Things have changed, even the Woods are almost gone now… but the way it used to be…

—It's alright if you don't want to go on…

—No, I'm okay. I can finish— she assured her. —Basically… Micah died almost three decades after Prime's defeat, and I accused Angella of "not doing enough", because she could have extended his life— she began, after a deep breath. —What I didn't know was that *he* had refused her offer to extend it… But I was just bitter and… I even ruined my relationship with Glimmer in the process— she went on. —I closed myself to everyone, only allowed Shadow Weaver to comfort me… She kept me in touch with the world, and made sure I wouldn't miss the integration, of course— she explained, sighing with melancholy. —Then, as the "ethical blood consumption" thing became an official ruling, she hired servants for this place, exhorted me to participate more in the Vampire Society too, and for almost twenty years, we enjoyed life together.

—If she was the same species I am… then she died quite early.

—Yes, Bea. But it was a miracle she made it that far— Castaspella clarified. —There you have yet *another* reason why you need to keep your use of sorcery to the minimum…

—I imagined…

—But… Well… The thing is… she eventually died. During her final years, she had managed to convince me to drink blood from the willing servants. Even though I didn't really want to, I couldn't keep taking her blood when she was already so weak…— she explained. —It made me think I shouldn't have taken her blood at all… But she encouraged me always, until her last breath, to continue living.

—Es…— Shadow Weaver uttered, reaching for her cheek to brush away a tear. —We can stop here.

—I'm fine, Bea… Don't worry— she insisted. —The part that comes now is rather pathetic, though… Centuries of me squandering my life…

—Don't say that…

—It's the truth— Castaspella sighed. —When she passed, I had no one to support me, so it hit me worse than Micah's death. Not because I cared for her more than I cared for him, but rather because I suddenly realized how painfully alone I was… I hid in grief, both for her and for my brother, and remained in my room— she told her, ashamed. —I refused to see Angella, who constantly came here asking for me; I only slept for decades, occasionally waking up to see the outside world through my window. The servants were… well, they were quite loyal. Shadow Weaver had arranged their payments in such a way that, as long as they remained in the mansion, they only needed to take care of the place as if it were their own and they would be fine— she went on. —I don't know how she did it, but the truth is, it worked. Whenever I woke up, after a decade or two of sleeping, they were always there, older, of course, and happy to see me— she told her with a smile. —They would offer me a bottle of blood for me to recover… Generation after generation, they always did the same. And, of course, the oldest tried to convince me to speak with Angella again…

—I remember the day you dismissed them— her wife recalled. —Now I understand what they meant… their expressions and words.

—That I should remember to invite Angella every decade, yes— Castaspella laughed. —That's because, after rejecting her visits for years, I finally agreed to meet her… I had been doing that hiding and sleeping thing for a hundred years… There was a lot I didn't know— she explained, sighing more. —Since then, I gave in to the servants' pleading and allowed them to wake me up whenever a decade had gone by, exclusively to have a chat with Angella and learn how the world was evolving.

—Why wouldn't you go out and see it for yourself?

—Angella tried to convince me, but I didn't want to leave this place… She came up with new reasons every time, but I kept turning her down. She even told me the Vampire Society had a seat saved for me in the Chapter formed to somehow lead the vampires, but I couldn't do it— Castaspella replied.

—Es…— her wife sighed, hugging her closer.

—Thank you, Bea…— she smiled, before kissing her head. —It took me around five hundred years to gather the strength to leave the mansion— she resumed, her expression more serious now. —The servants were thrilled when they learnt about it, they let Angella know, and the offer to join the Chapter was brought to the table again.

—I understand you took it…

—Not right away— she clarified. —The first night I left the mansion, I came across Hordak— she began. —I hadn't seen him in six centuries. I didn't know how to feel… what to say or do— she admitted. —And yet, he apologized… I told him he had nothing to apologize for but, as I said, I didn't know how to feel, so I asked him to keep his distance from me— she went on. —He

accepted but, before disappearing, he said he hoped I would take the seat at the Chapter; I still don't know why, but he seemed sincere…

—I don't like him, but I must admit he's, at the very least, respectful…

—Yes, that much is true— Castaspella admitted. —So, yes, eventually I joined the Chapter, I explored the world, made a name for myself in the Vampire Society, got recognition for my role in the uprising against Prime… And for being the reason we got integrated into society too…

—All that recognition is well deserved.

—Of course you would say that— she laughed. Then, after a deep sigh, she concluded —There's not much more to say… you know the rest of the story… Angella told me when she found Micah's reincarnation as a teen in Mystacor and *that* was when I met *you*, Beatrix.

—Funny how we also went from hating each other to a "friendship" and now… this…

—I'm glad I had more time to get to know you— she told her with a smile. —I wish I could have stopped you from performing the Spell of Obtainment, but at least I got you to delay it and keep Micah out of it… Enough of a change for me; he was never traumatized, he doesn't hate you…

—He opted out on his own…

—The circumstances were different; he was twenty instead of just fourteen, so he had better judgement.

—And I guess there was no Horde for me to join after the corruption— Shadow Weaver joked. —But I don't know what I would have done if you hadn't showed up…

—Bea… It happened because it had to happen… I need you to understand that. I was trying to stop the inevitable… Even if we hadn't fought, you would have eventually been triggered by *something else*…

—I know that, but… If you hadn't returned to stop me… I'm sure it would have been worse *somehow*.

—Yes! Damn it!— Castaspella exclaimed. —I-I'm sorry…

—What are you apologizing for?

—For what I'm about to say.

—Just say it, Es.

—Even if there was no Horde for you to escape to… Between your state of mind back then and your constant disagreements with Norwyn… I knew you would… *kill him*.

—Shadow Weaver killed Norwyn back then, right?— she realized. Castaspella nodded and held her tighter. —Then I should thank you…

—I did nothing…

—You did a lot: you kept me from becoming a murderer, and from traumatizing Micah, even if you couldn't stop my corruption— she pointed out. —So I'm guessing what you're doing now, keeping me in check at the Academy, is to make sure I won't traumatize my students like Shadow Weaver did with her wards at the Horde…

—She was… bitter, especially after what happened with Micah, and not only traumatized them. She purposely made Catra's life miserable, she manipulated Adora into thinking she had to be the perfect weapon for the Horde… instead of encouraging the kids, she pointed out their flaws and made them feel useless…— Castaspella enumerated. —I only hope these kids won't be scarred for life again.

—Well, I… must admit I'm very severe… and cold… I don't want to develop any attachments… But have I done anything to hurt them?

—Emotionally? Maybe… You're harsh. But I hope you haven't traumatized them. I mean… I'm not there after classes…

—Then I don't know what to say except that… I think they only dislike me because I'm generally mean… They don't seem to hate me viscerally, or fear me— Shadow Weaver reflected. —And… Well, they wished me goodnight, remember?

—Yeah— Castaspella smiled. —Alright, enough for the history class— she laughed. —We should get some sleep…

—Fair enough— her wife accepted. —Es?

—Yes?

—I… know I don't say it much, but I love you— she sighed.

—I love you too, Bea— she replied with a low tone, before kissing her head briefly.

Chapter End Notes

This is all for this year! But you can expect more backstory the next one! (^_^)

I don't have that many ideas, tbh, just some stuff.. but like, I'm enjoying writing this, and hopefully my notes will cease to be cryptic so I can properly elaborate on my idea lol

Anyways!
I really hope you enjoyed this little especial and Vampire Castaspella!!

See you next year or in another fic!!
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Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

Man… I MADE IT!?

Wow…

Anyways, this chapter is a fucking MESS
But it's also some good backstory!!

Ugh, I fr don't know what I'm doing, but I wanted to post this today, so I did…
And the editing was minimal, very shallow, so it's probably not my best work TT-TT

ANYWAYS, I hope you enjoy!!
Happy halloween!!!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

About a thousand years since Castaspella's turning.

She's been traveling for about four hundred years…

—Finally back home, Casta?— Angella asked, as her sister-in-law approached her.

—I am.

—Good timing— the Queen smiled, walking alongside her further into the castle. —I was going to track you down next week if you hadn't showed up— she giggled.

—Really, why?

—Let's sit to have some tea and I'll tell you— she proposed, inviting Castaspella into the dining room.

Once the tea was served, the Queen dismissed the servants and sighed deeply as she sipped her tea.

—Alright. We're having tea and are alone. Will you tell me now?

—Why don't you first tell me about your trips? A few hundred years of traveling around Etheria must have taught you something.

—I… guess. I can't say I feel any more grounded yet, and I'm definitely still far from finding any kind of purpose or desire to keep living… but I did see some nice landscapes and had time to reflect— Castaspella admitted, taking a sip of tea.

—That's good… I'd still prefer it if you *could* find a reason to live that is only yours and no one can take away, but… Ah… I guess that will eventually come. You have a lot of time now—

Angella said, letting out a sad smile.

—Alright. Enough deflection— the vampire sentenced, putting her cup down. —What is it? It's clearly important.

—It is— she nodded. —I… found Micah's reincarnation at last— she revealed, not daring to look at Castaspella. She wouldn't be able to bare her expression. —He's still a teen, so I won't meet him yet and, well, if things are meant to be, he will find me himself one day— Angella explained, stirring her tea with a spoon. —But I imagine you'd like to see him, and… I don't see why you couldn't.

—Well… I- That-that's good! A-and… Remember that Light Spinner was his tutor back then?

—Yes?

—Chances are, she's his mentor again— Castaspella pointed out.

—As… a matter of fact, yes, she is— Angella confirmed. —You do understand neither of them know you, right?

—I know, I know. But I mean… What if things are different this time? What if- I mean, he doesn't have to be traumatized again, you know?

—I get it, Casta, but you *must not* interfere with their current lives based on their past ones— the Queen warned her. —There are no guarantees that things will happen as they did before.

—Then I don't see the problem. If nothing bad happens between them, then I'd have no reasons to interfere— Castaspella remarked.

—Fair. I just wanted to warn you before giving you the address.

—He's in Mystacor again?— the vampire asked, reading the piece of paper the Queen handed her. —And an orphan once more, I see.

—However, he doesn't have a sister this time because, well, you never reincarnated. So, I suppose he's quite lonely now.

—Thank you, Angella— she sighed, expression somber.

She understood what the Queen meant.

It took her some time to finally dare visit Mystacor.

Not only had she been away for a long while, but also, her loved ones would be there again, just… not the same ones.

It was… hard.

After taking enough time to process it, Castaspella eventually traveled to the floating island, introduced herself as who she was, a vampire who had once been Head Sorceress of the guild, and asked to be shown around since she hadn't been to Mystacor in almost a millennia.

Naturally, the little tour around the place eventually got her face to face with none other than Light Spinner.

All her preparation was barely enough to keep her from crying the second she saw her.

But absolutely nothing could have prepared her for the *lack* of recognition in her eyes…

That hurt more than anything.

More than all those years alone.

—A vampire? *You* were Head Sorceress here!? There are no records of such a thing…

—Of course there wouldn't be. We were but a secret back then, so it was never revealed— Castaspella calmly replied, not falling for her disdain.

—And who exactly were you?

—That's irrelevant— the vampire denied. —If I were anyone important enough, you'd know already— she smirked.

—Right— she huffed.

—So!— Norwyn interrupted, possibly noticing the tension. —If you excuse us, Light Spinner, we must finish the tour around Mystacor.

—Oh, I wouldn't mind tagging along. Do you?— she asked, with fake niceness Castaspella could immediately spot.

—I most certainly don't mind. But if you're interested in *me*, I'd recommend a more direct approach instead of silently reviewing me while I'm *trying* to see how Mystacor has changed in the past few centuries…— she defiantly replied, shocking Light Spinner.

—How *dare* you…

—Speak my mind to you, without regard for whether it's proper or not?— Castaspella interrupted. —You see: I know your kind. I've known *worse*, so I regret to inform you that I am not falling for your tricks. And I'll see right through you…— she explained, completely ignoring Norwyn's efforts not to laugh.

—If that is your approach to a complete stranger…— she scoffed. —Then everyone wonders why I don't like socializing…

—Oh, no, you *love* socializing… but only as long as you can demonstrate your intellectual superiority in some way— the vampire smirked.

—Enough!

—Fine, fine— Castaspella giggled, raising her hands in a surrendering gesture. —But I must insist: if you want to figure me out, you'll have to take a more direct approach. For now, *please* allow me to tour Mystacor in peace.

—Deal. Norwyn…

—It's *Head Sorcerer* in front of guests— he reminded her.

—*Head Sorcerer*— she corrected herself, her tone dripping with mockery. —Could you do me a favour and point her to my workshop when you conclude the tour?

—If- Ah… Sure.

Later, once Castaspella had been shown around, and after a long chat with Norwyn, he did as promised and pointed her to Light Spinner's workshop.

Who would have thought… the workshop would be the same place where Castaspella usually went to study in solitude…

—Knock, knock— she said, peeking through the door which wasn't exactly closed, but rather ajar.

—Finally…— Light Spinner sighed.

—You couldn't have known I would come…

—Oh, I was sure you would, taking into account that you seem just as interested in me as you claimed I am in you…

—*I claimed*!? Don't start with that— Castaspella laughed. —You will be displeased to know I am aware of all your tricks. No, I don't know *you*, but I know enough. You can trust me.

—Sure…— the woman sighed. —How exactly would you be so *knowledgeable*? Don't tell me it's your millennia of life, I won't believe it…

—No, it is not.

—Then?

—It's the rather short time I spent with… someone. Who was… like you- Bah, I'd say worse, actually.

—A rather short time? I suppose this is related to how your extremely long life makes everything else seem short.

—Indeed. To be clear: My life *is* short compared to that of the Queen of Bright Moon. My life is long compared to yours as a mortal, and yet, you're a long-lived species, which means your life is long compared to that of humans, for instance…

—Correct.

—Well, I spent a few decades with this person… so much like you— Castaspella explained. —And that was during my initial years as vampire. For me, it was a lifetime.

—I see— Light Spinner sighed, pensive. —Alright, then, I'll drop my usual tactics and be direct: who are you, why are you so secretive about your identity, and why did you seem to… recognize me before Norwyn introduced us?

—Oh, so you noticed…— the vampire chuckled. —I'll answer your questions, but… only if you answer mine.

—Sure— she accepted, rolling her eyes.

—I am exactly who I said I was, I did not lie— Castaspella began. —But, since that keeps my name a mystery… You can call me Esmeralda. Now, what are you working on here?

—What makes you think…

—I used to study here. I recognize research when I see it sprawled on the floor.

—Fine…— Light Spinner grumbled, squinting. —I'm working on a huge project. My biggest one. May be quite a breakthrough— she revealed. —My turn: Why are you so secretive about your identity?

—Because I used to know many people here- Well, I should say I know the… ancestors of those living here now. If anyone were to track me down, to find my family… it would raise questions that the Vampire Community and the Queen of Bright Moon are not ready to answer.

—That's ridiculous— Light Spinner laughed. But when she saw the vampire was not laughing, she sighed. —Fine. What's your question.

—Are you working on the Spell of Obtainment?— she immediately asked, expression somber.

—How could you possibly know!?

—I've seen it before. I've met people who tried and failed to cast it… I know the consequences.

—No, that's-that's nothing like this. I'm improving it.

—Trust me, there are no improvements to be made that could work…

—How do you know!?

—Is that your question?— Castaspella asked back.

—Yes.

—Fine: I've been through this. I know what happens when you attempt to cast it, I know how it will affect you. Most people would *die*. You, most likely, will survive but will suffer greatly for it.

—That's not answering my question.

—It is. That's the answer: This has happened before. Millennia ago.

—No-no, it's not the same…

—If it isn't, you wouldn't mind answering my next question: are you getting help from someone to "fix" and cast this spell?

—What?

—Are you… getting help… from someone?

—How do you…

—Let me be more specific— Castaspella interrupted. —Are you getting help from a talented kid called Micah?

Light Spinner felt goosebumps.

Not only the accuracy of her words, but also her expression, were giving her a bad feeling.

—*Out*. I want you *out* of my workshop— the woman immediately stammered.

—I'll take that as a "yes".

—Out!

—You won't listen to me, will you?

—No.

—Even if I have vital information?

—Like I would believe you!

—A shame…— Castaspella sighed.

Now this meant… she'd have to go to Norwyn himself.

Part of her felt guilty for what she would do but, if she was honest with herself, this wasn't exactly *betrayal*.

She had given Light Spinner a chance instead of simply *assuming* she'd be as intransigent as the person she knew…

And, to no one's surprise, she was exactly as Castaspella expected.

Well, it wasn't exactly "lost time", since she had… perhaps too much of it.

In any case, she had listened to Angella. She wasn't interfering based on past-lives' experiences… she was interfering based on current-life's experiences, namely Light Spinner being stubborn and refusing to hear her out.

A real shame…

So she went to Norwyn and the current Council of Mystacor, explained how she had experience with the nasty Spell of Obtainment, and that after talking to Light Spinner and learning she would attempt it, putting a young kid in danger, she felt the obligation to tell them about it to stop tragedy from repeating itself.

As imagined, not even a week went by before Light Spinner sought Castaspella out.

—You!— the woman yelled, as soon as she saw her in one of Mystacor's gardens. —You dare keep coming here after what you did!?

—Me?— she asked back, pretending she didn't know what Light Spinner was talking about.

—Why is a vampire trying to ruin my life!?

—I am not…

—Whatever you think I did, I *didn't*!

—It's not what you *did*…

—I don't want to hear it, Esmeralda!

—Well, you'll have to!— Castaspella sternly retorted. —I'm not trying to *ruin* your life! I'm trying to keep *you* from ruining it yourself!

—Why do you care!?

—Look, you're right. I should let you be and if you die, you die. But I'm not letting you drag Micah into that. I'm not letting you hurt him, and I'm *absolutely* not letting you ruin *his* life!

—Why do you care about that kid!?

—Don't pretend *you* don't care…

—I didn't say that! But you don't know him! Why do *you* care!?

—I know I don't know *him*, but I don't need to in order to *not* want you to put him in harm's way! He's a *child*!

—He's more capable than that! He's *talented*!

—Still. A kid. Who can, and *will* get scared of that *thing* you're trying to summon!

—Enough! Stay out of my business!— Light Spinner ordered.

—I will, as long as you *forget* about testing the Spell of Obtainment— Castaspella bargained. —Keep it theoretical if you want, but do *not* attempt it, or I will do *anything* necessary.

Light Spinner was just as intransigent as in her past life.

The vampire had to make great efforts to remind herself this was not the same woman she had met… and loved.

However, being so much like her meant she knew what to do.

It was evident that, despite being proud and cocky, this Light Spinner seemed afraid of Castaspella… she took her threat seriously.

Hence, the vampire decided to linger on the island.

She'd arrive early and leave late; she was *always* there, pretending not to lurk…

Light Spinner tried to get her banished from the island, argued that Castaspella was harassing her… but couldn't prove it. And if that wasn't enough, the vampire even got an invitation to *teach a class*.

The sorceress was fuming.

But that wasn't the worst part for Light Spinner.

The worst part was that Micah admired Castaspella greatly, more each day, and most of the time would be speaking about her. He'd repeat over and over how he wished he had a sister like her.

Then one day he asked if he could call her "big Sis".

Light Spinner was ready to jump, indignant, but it was unnecessary.

—Please!?

—Oh, Dear, you know I'm a vampire, don't you?

—Yeah, but… I-I… I just want to… feel like I have a family— the teen sighed.

—I understand, Micah— Castaspella smiled, placing a hand on his shoulder. —You *will* have a family, that much I can promise— she assured him. —I wouldn't mind you calling me "Sister" but you must promise me that you'll keep in mind… I'm *not* your real sister— she insisted.

—I promise— he excitedly replied, eyes shining. —Wanna have lunch?

—Sure— she giggled.

From her hiding spot, Light Spinner watched them walk away, thinking, their voices fading but still understandable for a bit.

—Say, do you have a nickname? Can I give you one? Your name sounds really formal.

—You know, I do have a nickname: Casta. You can use it if you want…

She would speak to that vampire later. She needed to… discuss a few things.

And more importantly, she could respect the conditions she laid for Micah… but still wanted to understand *why*.

After Castaspella left Micah at the entrance of his next class, she walked away down the hall with a conflicted expression.

She did feel conflicted after all.

She wasn't sure how exactly to feel, after this young Micah single-handedly decided to adopt her as sister, since she had told herself it wouldn't be possible.

She didn't get her brother back, of course, this was a different person, but…

She wasn't that alone anymore, at the very least.

However, she was a bit distracted from reality, thinking about this and, and practically walked into Light Spinner. Good thing her reflexes made her stop, or that would have ended bad…

—Going somewhere?

—Ah… My apologies, Light Spinner…— Castaspella sighed.

—Is something wrong?

—No, no… Did-did you need anything? Or…

—I was looking for you, as a matter of fact— the sorceress admitted. —I heard you speaking with Micah earlier, and I want to talk…

—Don't tell me you're getting protective of him…

—Well, no, but…— Light Spinner began, yet interrupted herself and cleared her throat. —I actually… find it very… I-I think it was very sensible of you to make it clear you're not his sister, and I can respect that. But… I would like to speak privately, if you don't mind.

—As long as it's more cordial than the past few months…

—Of course. I suppose this is my way of apologizing— the sorceress sighed.

—I'm pretty sure you *never* apologize, but I'll take it— Castaspella giggled. —Sure, let's go.

They walked in silence until they reached Light Spinner's room, and the vampire didn't need more than a second to realize the woman literally lived there. She didn't just sleep there, she also ate there, presumably alone, and everything was clearly set for the woman to be comfortable.

She spent most of her time there… Why wasn't Castaspella surprised.

—Excuse the mess, I don't usually invite people here— Light Spinner began.

The vampire had to hold back from saying "I know", and instead replied —Interesting… But don't worry, I don't mind the mess.

—Alright, I'll go straight to the point then— the sorceress sighed. —Take a seat.

—Speak— Castaspella nodded, sitting down on a couch in front of the sorceress.

—I'll try to be brief, but this will certainly take some time: It's been a few months, you *somehow* are teaching here now too, and… I have to suppose you actually came here for Micah, not to "stop me" from performing the Spell of Obtainment.

—Interesting— Castaspella chuckled. —Actually, you're both right and wrong. I came for him, but I *also* came to make sure you wouldn't drag him into performing that damned spell…

—It can be revolutionary!

—No. Not in the way you think— the vampire calmly explained. —Listen to me, Light Spinner. This is no simple matter. This isn't something you can "test, fail, and start again" like you would with other spells…

—But…

—Please, trust me— Castaspella interrupted.

She was begging at this point.

—Can't you tell me why?

—I told you: the spell won't work, it will not kill you, but you'll wish it did, and… Micah doesn't deserve to lose you like that— she replied.

—This is all based on your experiences, but-but it may not be the same…

—Listen to me!— Castaspella insisted. —It's not- You have only proved to me that things *will* go the same way they did millennia ago… It's literally- I-I wish it would be different this time, but I don't think it's worth risking it!

—Esmeralda… I think… Ah… I don't know what to think— Light Spinner admitted. —Why are you warning me? Why not warn Micah?

—He admires you. You're his whole world, and if he loses you… Well, to answer your question, I don't think he would believe it, but mainly, I just don't want to put him against you…

—The boy is, what? Fifteen-years-old? He'd know better…

—No, trust me… He's still young and impressionable— the vampire insisted.

—Alright, I understand— Light Spinner sighed, looking down. —I'll… hold back from testing it, and… if I do test it, I'll make sure to keep him out of it.

—It'd be better, for yourself, if you just burnt that damned thing…— Castaspella began, raising a hand to stop her from interrupting because she knew what she would say. —But I know it's the work of your life, so yes, sure, keep it…

—Oh- I-I appreciate that. Ho-how did you know?

—Just trust me when I say I know people like you— the vampire laughed.

—Right…— Light Spinner nodded. —I- Uh, would you…

—Yes?

—Would you want some tea?

—Oh, so this is your apology! Of course, I'd love some tea— she smiled, holding back a smirk.

—If you mock me, there's no tea.

—I wasn't mocking you!— Castaspella giggled.

—Sure…

Suspicious still, but accepting the playfulness of the moment, the sorceress got up and went to prepare some tea.

Since then, and while they had tea, Light Spinner got… curious.

If Castaspella had really been Head Sorceress of Mystacor millennia ago, and if she had experienced so much, then what did she think of all her other projects?

For the first time in her life, the sorceress decided to ask someone for their opinion on her work.

And like that, they spent *hours* checking, revising, and discussing all of Light Spinner's projects.

They didn't even notice night fell until it was too dark to see.

Good thing Castaspella didn't have any other classes that day…

From that day on, the women entered some sort of friendly rivalry.

Light Spinner would constantly try to spite the vampire, she'd publicly defy her, and of course, they got into challenges many times.

But then, at the end of the day, they were little by little becoming friends.

They usually had dinner together, sat to have serious chats many times, especially when either of them considered their squabble that day could actually be pointing at something important, and every time the Moons of Enchantment aligned, Castaspella would invite Light Spinner to have a drink at the beach.

That night, the moons looked particularly nice…

It had been a few years now, maybe two or three, and Light Spinner hadn't attempted the Spell yet, nor had she made any references to wanting to do as much.

As the women laid on a blanket, hearing the cloud-waves come and go, Castaspella began dozing off.

She felt comfortable, at ease… Maybe too much.

Without noticing, she snuggled up to Light Spinner.

She didn't even think about it.

The sorceress, on the other hand, was suddenly *too* aware of this.

Frozen in place, she considered whether to wake the vampire up, pretend nothing was happening, or play along and, if anything, play dumb later…

However, as a particularly chilly breeze passed them, Castaspella woke up on her own and realized what she had done.

—Oh, shit- So-sorry— she immediately blurted out, sitting up. —I didn't- I wasn't…

—I know… Calm down— Light Spinner interrupted.

—No, really, sorry…

—Esmeralda— the sorceress cut her, sitting too. —I'm not upset.

—I…

—Are you?

—N-no… I mean…

—Listen: you were completely asleep, so I'll have to assume you just… confused me with…

—Yes— Castaspella nodded, before Light Spinner could fumble too much with how to call the mystery person she had *not* told her about.

—Then I'll take it as a compliment. I appreciate the trust— the sorceress smirked.

—It's not a good thing— Castaspella tried to deny, but Light Spinner unexpectedly placed a hand on her shoulder. —Please…

—What are you so afraid of?

—It's… I don't know if it's fear at this point— the vampire admitted, letting a few tears fall but smiling nonetheless.

—Then what is it?

—Shame?

—Why would you…

—Listen… I-I'm… confused, I guess— Castaspella sighed, looking down.

—Vampires can be confused like mortals? Well, that's a relief— the sorceress joked.

—Don't do that— she replied, chuckling. —It's not fair, Light Spinner.

—Beatrix— she corrected her. —Call me "Beatrix".

—Are… you sure?— the vampire asked, hesitant.

—Wouldn't have said it otherwise.

—True…

Time passed and, as their relationship improved, they also grew closer.

Everyone noticed as much, and Micah was *delighted*.

However, that made them the talk of the island, and that… sometimes got on their nerves.

—I'm just saying…— Light Spinner argued, trailing off with a sigh.

—Then go ahead and say it— Castaspella replied, already upset.

—You know what I mean.

—Look, I'm just as bothered by people's looks as you are, but that doesn't mean it didn't *hurt me*.

—I know, I know. But, seriously, it's not that important— she insisted.

—I'm telling you it *is* for me!

—Why!?— she inquired, yelling.

—Because it wasn't… easy for me… to accept… *this*.

—What do you mean "this"?

—Us.

—I…— Light Spinner began, yet cut herself. She refused to accidentally imply she didn't give their relationship as much importance as the vampire gave it, but she didn't want to lie either. —I apologize.

—How am I supposed to interpret that? Are you apologizing because of what you did, or because it will happen again?

—I don't- I am not in control, it was just a reaction.

—So you instinctively brushed me off… Your automatic reaction to me taking your hand in front of other people is to push it away, *disgusted*.

—No!

—Then what!?

—I wasn't- It wasn't disgust.

—Let me guess: It was fear. Because it's about being *seen* accepting a demonstration of love or whatever….

—Why do you question me if you already know what I'm…

—Because I want you to talk to me!— Castaspella interrupted. —And no, I don't "already know", I can infer it, but I *need you* to express what you're actually thinking and feeling!

—Well, I can't do that easily!

—I know!

—Then stop being so harsh!

—Are you *serious* right now!?

—What!?

—Ah… forget it— the vampire sighed. —I'll leave you alone…

—Wait— Light Spinner stopped her, catching her arm. —I apologize— she uttered. —Seriously.

—You don't mean it…

—I absolutely do— Light Spinner assured her, expression determined. Pulling her closer, she added —Let me make it up to you.

—How?— Castaspella asked, looking away without expecting much.

—I have something to give you— the sorceress said, swallowing hard. —It's… not how I planned to… Fo-forget it. I've just been cowering away from it, so… would you stay for a moment and let me give it to you?

—What is it?

—Stay here and you'll find out— Light Spinner smirked.

—Alright— Castaspella accepted, sitting down on the couch. —You have five minutes.

—I'll be right back.

Light Spinner rushed to another room while the vampire waited, feeling dejected.

She felt so stupid for allowing herself to, once again, fall for the same woman she *knew* hates love… and for letting herself think that, since this is a *different* person, technically speaking, that she could allow herself to have hope this time.

She had fallen so much into those pessimistic thoughts she didn't notice when the sorceress returned.

—Huh?

—I know this is weird coming from me, and I suppose this is actually a *terrible* time for it, but… I don't know how else to convince you I'm serious about us— Light Spinner began. —I'll understand if you refuse, Esmeralda— she then sighed, kneeling in front of Castaspella.

—Oh…— she let out, a bit too shocked.

Blushing deeply and looking away, the sorceress presented her with a simple ring.

She was also shaking subtly.

—Pretend for a moment that our life-spans aren't so different— Light Spinner pushed herself to begin. —Would you consider, at the very least, marrying me one day?

—You’re serious!?

—Absolutely— she confirmed.

Castaspella’s shock kept her speechless for a moment, just clutching the sofa with both hands.

She wasn’t sure what to answer now.

All those thoughts before were *so wrong*.

She wanted to accept… but why was she doubting?

Well, she couldn’t leave the woman waiting forever either.

—Bea…— she began, her eyes still on the ring. —I- Oh my Stars…

—You can say “no”…— she reminded her, lowering the ring and looking away.

However, Castaspella’s hands quickly caught hers, wrapping around the ring.

—I want to accept, but… Are you sure? You aren’t just rushing because of our fight?

—I am absolutely sure. I’ve been delaying this a whole year…— she admitted.

—And I never noticed…— the vampire realized.

—That was quite hard— Light Spinner smirked. —But yes, I’m sure.

Lifting her up like she weighted nothing, Castaspella stood up with the sorceress in her arms and kissed her deeply.

—Don’t make me angry anymore…

—Absolutely not happening. It’s part of the charm— Light Spinner mocked her. —But put me on the ground now…

—Oops!— Castaspella laughed, letting go of her. —Ahem… Yes, I’d like to marry you one day— she then smiled, offering the woman her hand to put the ring on.

—And I’ll try not to… brush you away anymore. I’ll be making a fool of myself if I did from now on— she pointed out.

—Well, if you think that's possible…

—That what is possible?— Light Spinner asked, raising a brow.

—Making a fool of yourself.

—No, of course I don't think so…— she replied, increasingly confused.

—Good! That means you'll make a real effort to avoid brushing me away!?— the vampire cheerfully said.

—O-of course!? Did you think I was joking?

—Maybe…

—Why!?

—It's hard to determine when you're serious and when not…— Castaspella pouted.

—I-I- O-of course I'd be serious in this situation! I was- I *never* intended to hurt you, but I did. A-and now I proposed to make it clear that I'm serious!

—I know, my Love, I'm messing with you— she gently smiled.

—Don't do that to me, will you?

—I don't think I can promise that, it was funny…— she snickered.

—Esmeralda!

—What!? It was!

—Of course not!

—And yet you do that to everyone all the time…— she smirked.

Light Spinner was now blushing furiously.

—It's not the same!

—Listen: I love you, including every stupid behaviour you have. So don't worry about it…

—I- Oh, thank you— she stammered, somehow even redder. —Is there a “but”?

—No “but”. Although I could ask something…

—What is it?

—What do you plan to do now? Should we make any… kind of announcement or wait for someone to see the ring and spread it?— she then asked, already holding back a giggle that she could not hide.

—Don't laugh… And yes, I think I'd rather wait for the news to spread on their own…

—Alright, alright. We'll do that, then…— she accepted, albeit giggling a bit.

—Thank you.

With a deep sigh, Castaspella gave the sorceress a long kiss and then sat back on the couch with her.

—Oh, just wait until Micah learns about it. He'll be so happy!

—Probably…

—You disagree?

—Yes, I disagree…— Light Spinner admitted.

—Why!?— the vampire asked, shocked.

—Because Micah is nineteen now… I think…

—What?

—I think his opinions may have changed a bit.

—But he's been really enthusiastic about us even as of late!— Castaspella argued.

—Yes, but he may also be more jealous now— Light Spinner pointed out.

—How!?

—He sees you as an older sister, he might dislike this…

—He sees you as a mother too, and he's always expressed that us being together was like a dream come true for him!

—No, well, but…

—But?

—But…

—You're turning red, you know?

—I-it's because you called me a "mother" to him or whatever…— the sorceress rebuked,squinting at her.

—I know you feel like that, and so does he…

—No, no. of course not!— Light Spinner scoffed.

—Bea!

—What!?

—I'm serious! And he'd be quite heartbroken if he heard you deny it, you know!?

—Please…

—No! Seriously!

—I’m serious too!— Light Spinner sentenced, getting into what Castaspella liked to call her “tutor mode”.

—You’re allowed to show you have a heart, you know?— the vampire mocked her.

Laughing and bantering light-heartedly, the women spent the rest of the day together…

Their first day of compromise, yet not their last day of arguing.

Their compromise did spread around on its own as Light Spinner expected.

However, that only made the issue of them being the talk of Mystacor even worse.

Now, not only were people whispering about them, but also, many would speak as if they were entitled to see proof that they are actually a couple.

And that, of course, meant the sorceress wanted to rip apart almost anyone they interacted with. It was so annoying that the vampire, and even Micah, wanted to let her punish all that insolent people.

But no, they couldn't.

They would always step between Light Spinner and whoever provoked her, remind her that she is in public, that she's a tutor, expected to be an example, and admit they wanted to allow her to shred the bastard to pieces, but couldn't…

Little by little, these things happened less, since people knew what could happen, and maybe also due to Castaspella giving them her most dangerous vampire smile.

Fortunately, in just a few months' time, those issues died down.

However, their internal issues didn't. But those were kept a secret, even from Micah, more often than not.

It was never easy to disguise how they were feeling, both women were open books for the young man, but he could still see the love between them, so he trusted whatever was happening would eventually pass…

It *always* passed.

And yet, there came a day, when the women argued, once more, about the infamous spell.

Light Spinner was being secretive, and that may have angered Castaspella even more…

—Alright, that's enough!

—What!?— the sorceress asked, as if she didn't know.

—I specifically told you…

—No, no, wait. If you're talking about what I think you're talking about, then you have no right! Absolutely no right!— Light Spinner interrupted, determined.

—Oh, then you *know* what I mean!? Why do you do it then!?— Castaspella asked, beyond disappointed.

—Be-be because…

—No excuses! Beatrix, please!— she begged.

Oh, Light Spinner couldn’t bear it when she did that.

—Stop with that!

—Why!?

—I don't want to fight you, Esmeralda, but…

—Then don't!— the vampire interrupted. —I have explained my reasons to you! Isn’t that enough!?

—No!

—Why!? Why is *nothing* enough!? Am I not enough!? Am I not… worth living for!?— Castaspella inquired, voice about to break.

—Look, Es, it was never… I didn't mean it like that. But I must…

—No! Stop with the "must"! There is nothing you "must" do! *Literally*!

—No, no! Of course I…

—No, I promise you, Bea… *nothing bad* will happen if you never test that spell, and *a lot* of horrible things will happen if you *do*!— the vampire insisted.

—I'm sorry, Esmeralda.

—If you really were, you'd never do this… At all— she replied, voice broken now.

—But I will. And I'm still sorry.

—Then I don't trust that!— she rebuked. —You don't feel "sorry", not enough…

—I swear, I do. But still…

—Then go ahead! Do it! But don't you fucking dare come to me afterwards! I can't- I won't deal with that again…— she sobbed, looking away.

She couldn’t… do this again.

—I… guess this is goodbye then— Light Spinner sighed. —But don't worry, Micah already refused. So he'll be safe.

—I care about you too!— Castaspella argued, voice strained from the effort. —But you don't care… About yourself, or about me… You just *don't*…

—I do this *because* I care!

—No, you don't! I can't with you!— she grunted, frustrated.

—Then good thing this is goodbye, no?— Light Spinner uttered, feeling abandoned.

—Ugh! Stop twisting everything! Why do you do this!?

—Because I *must*!

That damned word again…

—Fuck!

—Curse all you want, I'll be doing this tonight.

—Of course you will, and I'll have to leave you to rot on your own…— the vampire growled. —Why are we arguing about this again!?

—Because the argument always ended when you wanted, not when it *had* to end— Light Spinner pointed out. —And I mean, you always had the last word, but never really *listened to me*.

“Just like Norwyn” was left unsaid.

—There is nothing to listen to that I haven't heard before! Beatrix, I…

—Enough… Either leave already, or… stay and watch. I don't care.

—I will not “stay and watch”! I refuse to stay and do nothing to stop you! I can't see you do this to yourself!

—And if I am successful!?

—You won't be. Don't you understand you will *not* be successful!? And when they come to stop you at any cost, I won't be here to defend you, or to stop you from killing Norwyn for trying to take you down.

—Why would I kill…

—Still don't believe me? Still won't trust this has happened before?

—I can't believe it. No.

—A shame…— Castaspella sighed, looking down. —But then again, if you're so determined, then I shall leave, and you can do as you please, without interventions, without help, and more importantly, without anyone to save you when you *fall*.

—Esmeralda.

—What?

—Is this really it?

—If you go on, yes.

—I suppose, then… I am sorry.

—No, you're not— the vampire retorted, shaking her head.

—Why do you…

—I don't need you to apologize! You aren't sorry! You are *determined*! And you don't fucking care about the consequences, even when I explain them clearly to you!— Castaspella yelled, sometimes cut by her sobs.

—But…

—No, no. Stop— she interrupted. —Stop with the excuses and stop justifying this shit. You're doing this because you *hate me*! Because you *don't trust me*! And because you've *always been the same*: think yourself the smartest person in the room, and *need to demonstrate it*!— she argued, tears falling non-stop.

—Then you don't really love me…— Light Spinner replied, sorrowful.

—I do! I fucking love you even when you're so hard-headed!— the vampire insisted. —I never cared about that! But I thought you loved me just as much, enough to make different decisions! Enough to-to ditch that stupid spell!— she went on, voice strained. —Ugh! How has it survived a millennia!? I should have come to destroy it before you could find it!

—I don't believe that! It has to be- I-I *fixed it*! It *has* to be tested!

—Why did you return to this obsession all of a sudden!?— Castaspella asked, unable to understand how this was happening.

—Because no one respects me!

—I respect you! I *love you*! Micah respects you and looks up to you! What the fuck are you talking about!?

—No, no. No! None of that is true!— Light Spinner insisted. —You all laugh at my back because I can't even fix this stupid thing…

—Not true!

—It is… So now, leave— the sorceress ordered, expression darkened.

—Bea!

—*Leave*!

Castaspella was ready to stand her ground, yet Light Spinner summoned a spell with a flick of her hand and pushed her outside. Right after, she closed the door with a spell, leaving the vampire outside, crying on her knees.

When night came, as Castaspella returned home, knowing what would happen in Mystacor any time now, she could feel her tears falling.

Looking up at the Moons of Enchantment about to align, she let out a long sigh.

She couldn't stop her.

She could at least, kind of, save Micah from the danger of being right there when that parasitic magic was summoned; she could spare him seeing the woman he admires turn into a monster…

But what comes next…

Castaspella told herself there was no turning back now.

What came now was the inevitable.

She had delayed it, and should be thankful she got the time she got with Light Spinner, or that she managed to save Micah from the trauma…

But it still felt like giving up.

Could she?

Could she really… abandon her?

Or was the sorceress right and she didn't love her, actually!?

No, of course she loved her!

Then she had to go back.

Maybe she could burn the scroll before Light Spinner summoned the parasitic magic.

She would hate her, but she'd be alive…

The vampire went back to the Lunarium at full speed, expecting to find the woman about to begin with the spell.

However, she was instead met with a familiarly scarred woman, engaged in a violent fight with none other than Norwyn.

—Enough!— she yelled, hoping to stop them.

Yet they didn't hear her, so she'd have to act herself…

With her speed, it'd be easy to manage, of course, and with her sorcery, there would be no danger.

In the blink of an eye, Light Spinner, now corrupted, had been put to sleep, while Head Sorcerer Norwyn sat on the ground, apparently dizzy.

Oops? Maybe she had moved him too fast.

However, the sleeping spell didn't last long on the sorceress, and she was already waking up before Castaspella could explain anything.

—You!— she yelled, standing up from the ground.

—Woh, woh, calm down…— the vampire said, hands raised.

—I- What did you- What did you *do* to me!?

—I saved you, *fool*…— she mocked her.

—I'm not- Ugh… My head- My-my hands! What happened to me!?— the sorceress panicked, finally seeing her corrupted body.

—What I've been warning you about for years! You stubborn woman!— Castaspella groaned, standing right in front of her but not daring to touch her yet.

—No… But I… I felt so strong…— she argued.

—You *are* much stronger, but you could have *died*! And those new powers you've got!? They won't last for long!

—What is the… ugh… meaning of this?— the Head Sorcerer finally decided to ask, his head still spinning.

—I apologize, Norwyn. I couldn't stop her from performing the spell…— Castaspella decided to explain.

—I thought we were clear about this!— he remarked.

—Please, listen to me, Head Sorcerer. I-I'll take her away. Yes? We won't return to Mystacor… unless invited— she promised.

—She should be punished…— he argued, finally providing the sorceress with the last piece to make it all make sense.

The vampire was really trying to save her.

She… had been a fool, indeed.

—Trust me, the corruption of the Spell is punishment enough— she argued.

—Fine, fine. Forget it. Just take your things and go. Both of you— he ordered, still holding his head.

—Thank you.

With that, Castaspella helped the woman up, noticing her in shock now, and explained to her the deal she had just made with Norwyn.

There was no reply, nor was there resistance, so the vampire took her to her room… to empty it.

The sorceress was in shock for a long while.

She didn't react to anything, she went where Castaspella took her, sat where she left her, and didn't utter a word.

The vampire had to gather all of the woman's belongings in her stead, and no matter how hard she tried, she got no answers when asking if there was anything missing, any place she may not have looked into, or any other places in Mystacor where she could have left something.

—Beatrix, I need you to speak. Please— the vampire begged. —I-I'm sorry, alright? I apologize for-for the argument we had, I never meant to say I wouldn't- I shouldn't have told you it was over. I can't- I *love you*, I came back for you, so please, I'm begging, don't give up— she went on, tears gathering in her eyes. —Listen... I-I wasn't there the last time the Spell of Obtainment failed, so I don't really know if it's normal for you to be like this, or if you're in shock for some other reason, but I need you to snap out of it!

Silence.

The woman sill wouldn’t react.

Castaspella wasn't sure she even saw her; her eyes weren't really focused.

However, before she could keep trying, there was a knock on the door.

—Ca-Casta? Sis? Are you there?

—Micah?— she realized, immediately opening up. —What are you doing here?

—I... came to... help— he shyly replied. —How- Is she...

—She's far from okay— Castaspella scoffed, on the verge of breaking. —If you came to help, then, yes, come in. I need to fetch my things too— she sighed. —Bea is non-responsive, and I can't move everything myself, even if I came and go at top speed, it may take me too long...

—Where will she- Where are you taking her?

—To my home— the vampire gently replied. —I- Yes, I don't think she has anywhere else to go, and I won't abandon her...

—I thought you...

—I thought so too, but I can't— Castaspella admitted, looking down at her ring. —But... I mean, if she doesn't react soon, I'll probably have to take her to the hospital, or something.

Looking around all the gathered things, he decided —I'll help you take this all to your place and then we'll figure out what to do about her.

—Yes, yes— she nodded, a bit out of sorts. —I guess I can get a few boxes or crates to carry all of this...

—Or I can summon a box with sorcery— he proposed, smiling sheepishly.

—Yes— Castaspella smiled back. —That's smart.

Chuckling, he did as much and started to put things into the box.

—Let's take turns so we don't leave her alone— he then proposed, picking it up. —I'll be right back.

—Do you remember how to get there?

—Of course!— he nodded. —I don't remember if it's open, though.

—The servants can open, don't worry— she reminded him.

—Right! Okay, I'll be quick.

It took them less than an hour to empty the sorceress' room. She didn't have much, actually, but it always seemed like a lot to the vampire, maybe because everything was always a mess.

—Well, so, I will gather the few things I've been leaving around in the past few years, and then... I'll come for her.

—Alright. I'll... try to talk to her— Micah replied, sitting next to his mentor.

—Good luck— she sighed, walking out of the room.

There was silence for a moment while the young man considered what to say.

How to begin.

—I'm sorry, Master— he eventually sighed. —I don't regret not helping you, but... I should have... I don't know what I should have done— he admitted, looking down at his hands. —I wish there was- I wish you had listened to Casta...— he then said, finally looking at her. —If you- I don't know why you were so obsessed, but... look at you now! It's as she said! I-I don't- Can you talk to me? Can you tell me if you're in pain!? Is-is the- I'm sure it wasn't worth it, but I need to know if you realize it!— he went on, voice breaking and tears falling. —You were Light Spinner! You were- I *admired you*! And now I can't even... Now I'm here, trying to help you, but it's-it's not for you, it's for her! I can't explain what I feel when I look at you now, just that it's not the person you were! This is not my Master! You're no longer Light Spinner! I don't know what you've turned into, but... but I can see she still loves you— he continued. —She may not be my sister, not for real, but she's now the only person I have left who feels like family— he spoke. —You're a *stranger*. So long as she remains by your side, I'll be here too, but...— he hesitated, shaking his head. —I don't know who you're now. So either you talk, either you snap out of it and work with us to fix this mess... Or I will convince her of ditching you in some mental hospital.

Micah ended his monologue with rage; his shallow breath and balled fists implied as much.

But he hadn't noticed at first.

He then considered his words and realized he was just... sad.

He had lost his mentor, he was mourning her, and he was angry at the person that took her place.

However, Castaspella still loved her, didn't she?

He felt like Light Spinner had betrayed her, and he was furious for it! But he also realized it was not his place to feel like this.

There had to be something more he didn't know.

Maybe something related to the vampire's experience with the Spell.

Perhaps...

But still, he needed her to react, to say something, to speak!

To apologize!

Did she regret what she had done?

Was there any trace of remorse in her?

He needed to know; for Castaspella's sake, but also for his own.

But the minutes passed and the woman made no sound, no move.

She only breathed imperceptibly and looked ahead.

It angered him so much…

Yet, before he could say anything else, the vampire returned.

—Micah?

—She's still the same…

—I imagined— she sighed, approaching and kneeling in front of them. —I don't understand why, though.

—Can you tell me what happened at the Lunarium?— he asked, looking sorrowful.

—She was fighting Norwyn… Already corrupted when I arrived— she began. —She was, I don't know if normal, exactly, but she was responsive, panicked when she noticed her corrupted body… and then I calmed her down— Castaspella briefly explained. —But it's like she… disconnected from herself entirely.

—I see— he uttered. —Do you… think this is still her? In any way?

—I'm sure this is still Beatrix— she first confirmed. —But… maybe not the same person you knew — she then clarified. —Light Spinner is gone.

—I guessed as much— he nodded, thinking about his words just earlier. —Did you know this would happen?

—I- No. Not exactly— she considered. —I am sure it could have been… far worse— she sighed. —My intervention surely changed what could have been— she attempted to explain, without revealing more than she should.

—How so?

—I can't- It'd be just speculation. It's not worth thinking about.

It took her a long while to finally react.

Castaspella and Micah took her from Mystacor down to Castaspella's home in the Whispering Woods, and left her to rest in a room.

Then, she offered him some tea and told him he could wait around or leave if he preferred.

There was no further conversation between them, and eventually, he fell asleep on a couch while she sat to read…

It was dawn, he hadn't slept yet.

As time went by, the vampire had her servants check on her every once in a while, until they finally told her the woman was asking for her.

—I'll be there. Thank you— she nodded. Quickly glancing at Micah, she noticed him still asleep and preferred not to bother him. Finally, she went to knock on the door and asked —May I come in?

—Ye-yes…

—How are you feeling, Bea?— she asked, stepping inside and closing the door behind her.

—What did I do, Es?— she uttered, sitting on the bed, hunched over.

—You… did whatever you wanted— Castaspella scoffed. —You fought Norwyn… You got banished from Mystacor.

—What!?— she gasped, looking up at her. —Why- How!?

—They wanted to punish you. I convinced Norwyn of letting you go. But you can't return.

—I see…— she sighed, lowering her head. —I didn't listen to you. And I lost everything…— she uttered, hunching further. —Where am I?

—In my home— the vampire replied, brisk. —All your things were brought here too.

—I thought you said…

—Forget what I said— she interrupted, severe. —I am angry still, and disappointed. But, if you're willing to listen to me from now on, then I'll help you recover.

—Why?

—Because, like it or not, I love you— she scoffed. —Right now I'd *love* to knock some sense into you, but I think you're already beating yourself up enough…

—You should have let Norwyn kill me— the woman sighed.

—Shut up— Castaspella grunted, rolling her eyes. —You were drunk with power, you have no idea what you could do, and you've been in shock for hours. So better get yourself together and cooperate, or you'll make this more difficult for us both.

—What exactly do you plan?

—I plan on getting you a chance to make it up for your mistakes— the vampire sentences, folding her arms. —Back in my day, when I was mortal, you would have been… likely put to work for the kingdoms affected— she considered. —I am guessing Norwyn will prefer to keep you as far as possible, but the laws of this world have changed in all this time; it won't be his decision alone to make…

—I don't get it…— the sorceress admitted.

—What you've done… Beatrix, it's technically a crime— she sighed. —And you can be sure that Norwyn will get the Queen to put you on trial for it.

—You can't use your connections with authorities to help me— she argued, but quickly noticed something in Castaspella's expression. —And you don't plan to… Then what do you mean?

—I have authority of my own I can use— she explained. —But like I said before, I need you to cooperate. I don't mean you have to act submissive and obedient, but don't be difficult, set aside your pride… and listen to me this time.

As a vampire, and because of her role in history, Castaspella had a seat in what was known as the Chapter; the elite of the Vampire Society.

She had joined just a few hundred years earlier, before traveling around the world, and never really used her authority for anything…

Yet now was the time.

If her seat at the Chapter meant anything, this was the perfect moment to test it.

She had the recognition of her peers, Angella would likely support her however she could…

All that she needed now would be, apparently, Norwyn's acknowledgement.

After a few days, during the first hearing, the Chapter, the Queen, and the authorities of every kingdom of Etheria gathered to discuss what happened in Mystacor.

As she concluded her argument, it was time for Norwyn to speak.

—I understand your point, and since the beginning I've trusted you— he firmly said. —You warned us about the Spell of Obtainment and Light Spinner's obsession with it. However, she still performed it, she got corrupted, and could have doomed us all— he went on. —Given your now-close relationship to her, and since this closeness predates the attempt by years, I have to insist that you're biased in her favour, and unfit to judge her. You *allowed her* to cast the Spell.

—With all due respect…— a male voice interrupted, careful but *dangerous* in tone. —I'll take it that you are unfamiliar with the rules of the Vampire Society.

—I- Uh, yes, I'm unfamiliar— Norwyn admitted.

—Can you explain your point, Hordak?— Queen Angella requested.

The Head Sorcerer of Mystacor went pale when he heard the name.

—I shall— he accepted. Standing up, Hordak began —It is a fairly unknown fact that our world works in cycles. After a thousand years, souls reincarnate in the same person then once were, hence, every century, history has a chance of repeating itself with more or less exactitude. When we speak about things that "may happen", we are vague for a reason.

—But I know that…

—No, Head Sorcerer, that wasn't what I meant— Hordak denied. —That is context, which you actually didn't know, only inferred. Am I correct?

—Ye-yes— Norwyn admitted, looking away.

—What I want to point out, is that this context I explained is the foundation of an important rule: we cannot interfere in present history based on past history— he clearly explained. —When our fellow decided to warn you, she gave you a chance to change what would happen. And, in fact, as far as I'm concerned, she did significantly change history…

—How exactly?— the sorcerer scoffed, folding his arms.

—You're alive— Queen Angella revealed. —I agree with Hordak here— she admitted. —I personally told Castaspella not to interfere, and she followed the rule without breaking it, even if she pushed it a bit. What you're arguing regarding her bias is, at the very least, unfair.

—While their relationship may be too close for her to judge her objectively, Castaspella has explicitly told us as much— Hordak went on. —She's here to give us her opinion; *because* she knows her so well, no one is better fit to tell us if our final sentence for her will improve or worsen her behaviour.

—Bu-but…

—What are your objections?— the Queen inquired.

—None— Norwyn finally replied. —As long as she never sets foot on Mystacor again, I have no objections.

—If no one else has anything to add, then we'll proceed to decide whether further actions need to be taken regarding Beatrix— she sentenced.

After a long deliberation, the Vampire Society and the Princess Alliance came to the conclusion there were no more necessary restrictions. The woman would be banned from the floating island, and maybe kept under vigilance, but that would be all.

The woman herself couldn't believe it, and for a while she felt ashamed.

It took Castaspella a few years to get the woman back on her feet, but little by little she managed as much.

She began taking jobs as understudy sorcery teacher, which were scarce outside Mystacor, and most times frustrated her.

She felt everything was… too simple. She would only teach very basic things, and of course, she was never taken as permanent teacher because she was “overqualified”.

On the other hand, bigger academies and institutes where she could be a better fit, required her to have “significant experience teaching”, which she had none outside of her mentoring in Mystacor… which she couldn’t prove.

After all, that experience belonged to Light Spinner…

And now, she was gone.

Now, there was only Shadow Weaver.

Five years since the incident and corruption of the sorceress, Castaspella was struggling not to give up.

She felt like she had lost the woman she met, the woman she came to love…

She had become bitter, angry, and fatalistic.

Perhaps her fiancée was no longer there.

However, the same day she was preparing to actually put an end to their relationship, the vampire learnt that Queen Angella and Micah had finally met.

It had been by mere chance, and the way he spoke to her about the chance encounter was so filled with admiration and excitement… Castaspella was sure they would once again get together and, eventually, have Glimmer.

History had its way to fall into place regardless of what they did… But at the same time, it made her wonder: to what extent were relationships part of history? And what could be considered to be “fate”? What did it mean when they said people were “meant to be”?

Who meant it?

What if *she* meant it!?

Why give up on her love, why abandon her fiancée, other than lack of love?

Yet that was exactly it: she still loved the grumpy, mean, insufferable woman…

That same night, Castaspella sat with Shadow Weaver to have dinner.

—Last day today?

—Yes…

—How was it?

—Pitiful…— the woman grunted, moving around her food without eating.

—Like every time, I guess…— the vampire sighed, sipping her cup.

—Es, I know how you're feeling— she finally said. —I can see you're… not happy.

—Bea… It's not your fault.

—It is— she interrupted. —So, if you want me to leave, your house and your life, just say it.

—I don't— Castaspella firmly denied. —That's the thing, I don't want you to leave.

—But…

In a second, she was behind Shadow Weaver, holding her shoulders and whispering on her ear.

—I mean it every time I say I love you— she began. —If you allow me, I want to try harder to show it… and I hope you'll do the same for me…

—Es— the woman muttered, goosebumps running through her body. —I'm not worth it…

—You are— she insisted, one hand cupping her chin, and the other pressing down on her chest, where her heart-beat accelerated. —You were before, I don't see why you can't be again, if you decide so…

—Why… now?

—Because I just realized I will lose you if I keep doing *nothing*— Castaspella admitted, rolling her eyes. —And, if I'm honest, I don't want that. If you want to leave, you can… but I hope you don't want to— she added, her tone lowering as it became a whisper again.

Chills once more.

Castaspella's fingers seemed more clawed than before as she traced the edge of her chin, and followed the line of her scars down her chest.

She could also feel her breath on her neck.

A reminder that this was a *vampire* and not a mere woman?

But Shadow Weaver knew this was not fear she was feeling.

This was arousal.

Letting out a shaky sigh, exhaling the air she didn't know she was holding, the woman gathered all her courage to speak.

—Maybe you'll have to convince me to stay…

Perhaps, if she had seen the spark of lust on the vampire's eyes, she *would* have been a bit afraid…

That night, their relationship was rekindled and burnt brighter than before.

For the first time since her corruption, Castaspella felt like the woman she knew was there again.

But she guessed this was nothing more than a placebo.

If she really wanted their relationship to thrive, if she wanted this woman to eventually become her wife as they had discussed long time ago… they would both need to put in the work.

Hence, every day since that day, they tried to help each other out.

Castaspella didn't need to work, but had connections and could get any job she wanted… so she began working along-side Shadow Weaver whenever she got an offer, and helped her make the most of it.

On her part, the sorceress made a promise to the vampire to improve herself, to change her behaviour, and to be more open, at least with her.

That way, the couple little by little improved their relationship, communication, quality time, and even their public image.

Castaspella was more active within the Vampire Society and the Chapter, Shadow Weaver began building her name as a capable tutor *despite* her corruption; they were often seen going to the Opera, attending Royal events, and sometimes even visited the Queen outside of business meetings.

All in the span of two years, maybe a bit more.

However, this meant that, when the public learnt the Queen was pregnant, the press immediately went to get interviews with Castaspella and Shadow Weaver about the scandal, and whether they were aware of this.

Maybe the worst part was that they… were not.

That year was quite loaded for them…

It started with the Queen's scandal, which lasted a few months until the whole Alliance managed to get the press to drop the matter.

Then, the Vampire Society had a "tiny" incident with some of Entrapta's inventions, which almost resulted in the revelation of her true age and nature…

During the second-half of the year, Castaspella and Shadow Weaver decided to get married at last, which meant a *lot* of preparations were crammed up into a few months.

And finally, very fortunately, Shadow Weaver got a job at a prestigious academy in Bright Moon, as a permanent tutor, the first one to ever do full mentorship of boarding and day students alike.

Since she was well-versed in several subjects, she could do general teaching of any of them, or all in this case. Moreover, she demonstrated pedagogical skills, so they considered her fit to oversee boarding pupils, who were mainly orphans taken in by the academy.

The first few months, Castaspella only asked her about this new job every night and limited her involvement.

Until one night, Shadow Weaver finally triggered all her alarms.

—How was it today?

—Quite well, actually…

—You seem in a better mood than usual— the vampire chuckled.

—I suppose I am— she admitted, slowly eating her meal. —We got a new arrival…

—Why do you call new admitted orphans…

—It's shorter than saying all of that, *and* it's also what the academy officially calls them— Shadow Weaver interrupted.

—Alright. What's got you so happy about this one?

—I don't know if "happy"— she began, dubious. —It's just the first time I've got to receive an orphan *baby*— she clarified.

—A… baby!?

—No one knows who left her at the door… It's incredible— Shadow Weaver sighed, rolling her eyes. —But, what's worse, we have no information of her, no name, no nothing… She was just… *left there*.

—I can't believe it…

—Me neither— she smirked. —Specially because they made *me* name her!

—What!? Wait, and what did you call her!?

—Well, I've never had to name a kid, as you can imagine, so perhaps I'm not very original, but they saw nothing wrong with the name I chose…

—What about telling me at last!?— Castaspella insisted, knowing fully well that the woman was delaying it on purpose. —Don't keep me in suspense!

—I could only think about how adorable she looked with her big blue eyes, so I called her…

—Adora— the vampire uttered, connecting the dots a bit too fast.

—How did you- Alright, I get it. It's too basic— she sighed, folding her arms.

—No! No, of course not… I didn't mean- I'm sorry, Bea. I wasn't…

—It's alright, don't stress about it— Shadow Weaver dismissed her. —Speaking of babies, I meant to ask: have Micah and Angella decided on the name yet?

—They have a few options, yes…— she replied, looking away.

—Sounds to me like it's already decided— the sorceress guessed, smirking. —Which of them doesn't know yet? I bet Micah…

—Correct— Castaspella chuckled. —She'll convince him, eventually…

—And the wedding? Or have they decided against it?

—No, no… Angella just wants to make it after she's born- Uh, once the baby is properly settled and all… Maybe in a year or two.

—Makes sense— Shadow Weaver sighed, focusing back on her dinner.

The following day, after the woman left for the academy, Castaspella went to see Angella and called the Chapter to join the meeting.

—I am sorry to gather you in such short notice, but I need to discuss something important, regarding Beatrix, and our rule about interfering with present history…

—This is about the child, isn't it?— Hordak interrupted.

—What child?—Angella asked.

—So you left her there, didn't you!?— Castaspella realized. —Why did you abandon Adora at the academy!?

—Adora!?— the Queen reacted, increasingly confused.

—Shadow Weaver named her back then; it is integral to her development to be raised by her too— Hordak explained. —I cannot reveal how she ended on my hands, but I can assure you: it's how it had to happen.

—Listen: if what you're saying is true, then all her wards from the Horde back then will end up at the academy under her care again— Castaspella began. —I don't like the prospects…

—Wait- Adora was…

—Sorry, Angella— the vampire interrupted. —Yes, she's been admitted at the Academy and now Beatrix is in charge of her…

—And what would be the problem? Why are we here?

—I don't want Adora, or any of the other kids, to suffer Beatrix like they did back then with Shadow Weaver— Castaspella fully explained.

—Then what do you propose?— another vampire asked, raising a brow.

—That's what I don't know— she admitted. —I don't think she should lose her job there, but I can't sit and watch as she mistreats those kids in the years to come…

—And if she doesn't mistreat them?

—That would be ideal, but there are no guarantees that's possible, only proof of the opposite.

—Then supervise her again— Entrapta chimed in, startling everyone except Hordak. —Whoops! Sorry, I was not supposed to interfere…

—Wait… That is a good idea— Angella considered. —Like you did with Micah: you can be there to keep Shadow Weaver under control, at least partially… You'll only need to interfere if there's a reason to.

—I-if you give me permission, then I will— Castaspella accepted.

—I don't see why not— other members of the Chapter agreed, nodding.

—We can get you a role as Professor Assistant to Shadow Weaver; that will get you some hours to oversee her. But there is no way you can supervise her beyond that without proper reasons given to the academy… And to her— one of her fellows explained.

—That's something, at least. I'll take it— Castaspella accepted.

—In that case, I suppose this meeting can be dismissed— Angella sighed. —I expect no further issues arise from from this matter, or we'll have a word, Hordak…

Chapter End Notes

Alright, so… I hope that wasn't too hard to read, and I REALLY hope I can continue this next year…

But I won't make promises this time…

I really enjoy Vampire Castaspella a lot, so I *want to* write more, but the muse is being a bitch rn!!
I also have to finish something else for this monday…

ANYWAYS

HAPPY HALLOWEEN!! I HOPE U HAVE A NICE DAY!
AND THANKS FOR READING!!!! ^w^

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!